



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

CONTENTS

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col. 6]

MOTIONS—

- (a) Report on the Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulations, 2025 — [Col. 10]
- (b) Report on the Public Private Partnership Regulations, 2025— [Col. 22]
- (c) Immigration Service (Amendment) Regulations, 2025 — [Col. 33]
- (d) Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025 — [Col. 44]

BILLS —THIRD READING—

Social Protection Bill, 2025— [Col. 1]

PAPERS—

- (a) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Atwima Kwanwoma District Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 3]
- (b) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Prestea- Huni Valley Municipal Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 3]
- (c) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Juaben Municipal Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 3]
- (d) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ga South Municipal Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 3]
- (e) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Asutifi North District Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 3]

- (f) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Obuasi East Municipal Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 3]
- (g) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Assin North District Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 3]
- (h) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Sekyere Central District Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 4]
- (i) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ga West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 4]
- (j) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Suame Municipal Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 4]
- (k) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Bosome Freho District Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 4]
- (l) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Upper Denkyira East Municipal Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 4]
- (m) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the New Juaben South Municipal Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 4]
- (n) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Sekyere Afram Plains District Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 4]
- (o) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Offinso North District Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 4]
- (p) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ahafo Ano South West District Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 4]
- (q) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Sekyere South Municipal Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 5]
- (r) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Abura-Asebu-Kwamankese District Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 5]
- (s) Annual statement by the Audit Committee of the Tamale Metropolitan Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 5]
- (t) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ho West District Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 5]
- (u) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ablekuma West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 5]
- (v) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Accra Metropolitan Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 5]
- (w) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ejisu Municipal Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 5]
- (x) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Techiman Municipal Assembly for the year 2024— [Col. 5]
- (y) Exemptions Regulations, 2025— [Col. 101]

ADJOURNMENT— [Col. 102]

Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

BOUND VOLUMES of the Official Report (each with a comprehensive Index) are issued periodically during the Session. There is no fixed subscription rate, but prices will be quoted on each publication.

*Published by Office of Chamber Reporting,
Parliament House, Accra.*

*Designed and Printed by Publishing Department,
Parliament House, Accra.*

©2025 Parliament of Ghana.

THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Thursday, 31st July, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber of
Parliament at 3.17 p.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR
BENARD AHIAFOR, IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr Richard Acheampong (Second Deputy Whip): Mr Speaker, with your indulgence, I would want to respectfully plead that we vary the order of Business and take the Motion numbered 16. Yesterday, we did not put the Question, so we would move the Motion for it to be seconded so that you put the Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Minority Whip, what is your view?

Deputy Minority Leader (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, we do not have any difficulty on that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us turn to page 6, the item numbered 16. There is a Question to be put on the Third Reading of the Social Protection Bill, 2025.

BILLS —THIRD READING

Social Protection Bill, 2025

Question put and Motion agreed to.

The Social Protection Bill, 2025 —
read the Third time and passed.

[Hear! Hear!!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us now look at the *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 30th July, 2025.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, I was hoping I would catch your eye, but if the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection could help us lay the Papers on behalf of the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Before we take the *Votes and Proceedings*?

Mr Ayariga: Yes, before we take the *Votes and Proceedings*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection is happy this morning, so she can do that, except that the Majority Leader is not telling us the whereabouts of the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. If we know the whereabouts of the Minister and why the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection has to do that, then she can go ahead.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, he is not in the Chamber.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, let us take the item numbered 7(b). Hon Members, let us take all of them together.

PAPERS

By the Minister for Gender and Social Protection (Dr Agnes Naa Momo Lartey) on behalf of the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs—

- (i) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Atwima Kwanwoma District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (ii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Prestea- Huni Valley Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (iii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Juaben Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (iv) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ga South Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (v) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Asutifi North District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (vi) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Obuasi East Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (vii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Assin North

District Assembly for the year 2024.

- (viii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Sekyere Central District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (ix) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ga West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (x) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Suame Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (xi) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Bosome Freho District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (xii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Upper Denkyira East Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (xiii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the New Juaben South Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.
- (xiv) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Sekyere Afram Plains District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (xv) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Offinso North District Assembly for the year 2024.
- (xvi) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ahafo Ano

South West District Assembly for the year 2024.

(xvii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Sekyere South Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(xviii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Abura-Asebu-Kwamankese District Assembly for the year 2024.

(xix) Annual statement by the Audit Committee of the Tamale Metropolitan Assembly for the year 2024.

(xx) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ho West District Assembly for the year 2024.

(xxi) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ablekuma West Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(xxii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Accra Metropolitan Assembly for the year 2024.

(xxiii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ejisu Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

(xxiv) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Techiman Municipal Assembly for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Local Government and Rural Development

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we can now do the *Votes and Proceedings*.

3.17 p.m.

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we now turn to the item numbered 5 — Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* of 30th June, 2025.

Page 1...7—

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, and in all humility, I wish to seek your judgement yet again on page 7, the item numbered 4 (22). The last time, I raised this very issue, given the fact that the Electoral Commission (EC) has now officially communicated to the public about the unfortunate demise of our Colleague.

Mr Speaker, at what point would the *Votes and Proceedings* cease to capture his name?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, once you have received the Communication, let us do the needful. You cannot mark a deceased person absent. You indicated here that the person is deceased, yet absent. It is as if you expect a deceased person to be present. He is, however, not present, and you mark him absent. So, let us do the needful. Thank you very much for the observation.

Page 8...10 —

Mr Felix Kwakye Ofosu: Mr Speaker, I crave your indulgence to allow me to take you back to page 7, if I am not mistaken. I noticed that I have been marked absent, but I was here yesterday. It is just that I neglected to sign the attendance sheet. But I was definitely here yesterday.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Table, kindly take note.

Page 10...15 —

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah: Mr Speaker, on page 14, the second line of the item numbered 4, “vulnerable communit”. If the spelling could be corrected.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Table, kindly take note.

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, that was exactly my observation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Good observation.

Page 15...20—

Nana Osei-Adjei: Mr Speaker, the item numbered 1, the Committee on Roads and Transportation, met on Wednesday, 16th July, 2025 at 1: 30 p. m. but on page 23, the Meeting ended at 11 a.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is it 11 p.m. the following day or the same day.

Nana Osei-Adjei: Mr Speaker, I need your guidance.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table Office, kindly take note. Sometimes, it may be as a result of the communication from the Clerk of the Committee to the Table Office. So, they will cross-check.

Nana Osei-Adjei: I am guided, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Page 24 —

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, still on page 23, the item numbered 1, it reads:

“The Committee embarked on a working visit to the Ghana Police Service on Tuesday 17th of July...”

17th July, should be Thursday and not Tuesday.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Table, kindly cross-check whether it is on the 16th or 17th, or on Tuesday or Wednesday.

Page 24...30

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 30th July, 2025, is accordingly adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have two *Official Reports*. They are dated Wednesday, 23rd July, 2025, and Thursday, 24th July, 2025, for correction.

Hon Members, let us take the *Official Report* of Wednesday, 23rd July, 2025. Any correction?

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Wednesday, 23rd July, 2025]

We now turn to the *Official Report* of Thursday, 24th July, 2025. Any correction?

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Thursday, 24th July, 2025]

Yes, Majority Leader? Do we take the Motion numbered 9 and finish up with it?

All right. Motion numbered 9, Chairman of the Committee?

MOTIONS

Suspension of Standing Order 104 (1)

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 104(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that a Motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the motion is given, the Motion for the adoption of the Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulations 2025 may be moved today.

3.38 p.m.

I so move, Mr Speaker.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 10, Chairman of the Committee.

MOTIONS

Report on the Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulations, 2025

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah): Mr Speaker, with respect, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulations 2025.

Mr Speaker, with your kind permission, I present the Committee's Report and advice that the *Hansard* captures the entire Report as having been presented.

Introduction

The Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulations, 2025 was laid by the Hon Minister responsible for Environment, Science, Technology and Innovation, Dr. Murtala Muhammed Ibrahim, on 24th June, 2025. The instrument was laid pursuant to Article

11(7) of the Constitution and Order 100 of the Standing Orders of Parliament

In accordance with Order 220(3) of the Standing Orders, the Rt. Hon. Speaker referred the instrument to the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation for consideration and report.

Deliberations

The Committee met to consider the draft Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulations, 2025, in accordance with article 11(7) of the Constitution and Orders 100 and 220 (4) of the Standing Orders of Parliament.

In attendance to consider and deliberate on the draft Instrument were the Chief Director at the Ministry of Environment, Science, Technology and Innovation Ms Suweibatu Adams, the Director Legal of the Environmental Protection Authority, Ms. Abena Ayensu, the Acting Deputy Chief Executive Officer of the Petroleum Commission, Mr. Nasir Alfa Mohammed, and officials from the Office of the Attorney-General's Department and Ministry of Justice.

The Committee expresses its profound gratitude to the Hon Minister and the officers from the Ministry as well as officials from the Office of the Attorney-General for attending upon the Committee to provide clarification to the Regulations.

Reference Documents

The following documents were referred to by the Committee during its deliberations:

- a. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;
- b. The Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana;
- c. The Environmental Protection Act, 2025 (Act 1124);
- d. The Environmental Protection Agency Act, 1994 (Act 490);
- e. The Environmental Assessment Regulations, 1999 (LI 1652);
- f. The Draft Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulation, 2025;
- g. Report of the Stakeholder Consultations on the Draft Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulation.

The Scope of the Committee's Mandate

The Committee was guided by the provisions of article 11 (7) of the 1992 Constitution and Standing Order 220 (4) in considering the referral. These provisions enjoin the Committee to determine whether a Regulation under consideration:

- a. is in accordance with the Constitution or the Act under which it is made;
- b. contains any matter which should more appropriately be dealt with in an Act of Parliament;
- c. contains imposition of any tax;

- d. directly or indirectly bars the jurisdiction of the courts;
- e. gives retrospective effect to any of the provisions in respect of which the Constitution or the Act does not expressly give that power;
- f. involves expenditure from the Consolidated Fund or public revenues;
- g. appears to make an unusual or unexpected use of powers conferred by the Constitution or the Act pursuant to which the Regulations were made;
- h. appears to have been unjustifiably delayed in its publication or in laying it before Parliament; and
- i. for any reason, in its form or purpose, requires clarification.

Background

The Government of Ghana, as part of its strategic plans to develop petroleum systems within the onshore Voltarian Basin, intends to expand and open the basin for oil and gas exploration. This initiative has created the need to establish comprehensive regulations governing both offshore and onshore oil and gas operations, as well as to formulate specific guidelines for exploration and related activities within the Voltarian Basin.

As early as 2011, the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA), with support

from the Norwegian Oil for Development (OfD) Programme, developed and published Guidelines on Environmental Assessment and Management for Offshore Oil and Gas Development. These guidelines aimed at assisting environmental consultants and industry stakeholders in addressing environmental management issues.

In response to Ghana's emerging upstream petroleum sector, the guidelines served as a critical tool in preparing the EPA for the development of a comprehensive environmental legislation tailored specifically to the upstream oil and gas industry.

Following several years of implementation of the guidelines alongside the Environmental Protection Agency Act, 1994 (Act 490), and the Environmental Assessment Regulations, 1999 (LI 1652) the EPA recognized the need to transition the guidelines into binding regulations. This move is intended to strengthen the EPA's regulatory framework and enhance its capacity to effectively enforce environmental compliance while protecting the natural environment.

The Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulations, 2025 forms part of the EPA's strategic plan to elevate the original guidelines into a formal regulatory instrument. The goal is to develop a unified regulatory framework that addresses both offshore and onshore oil and gas operations, with a particular focus on the unique environmental considerations of the Voltarian Basin.

Purpose of the Legislative Instrument

The objectives of the Regulations, as outlined under Regulation 1 of the draft Legislative Instrument are to ensure:

- a) the issuance of permits and licences for petroleum and petroleum-related activities;
- b) the management of waste resulting from petroleum operations;
- c) minimising the flaring and venting of gas;
- d) emissions and discharges of harmful or noxious substances and materials into the external environment;
- e) emergency planning, preparedness and response against oil pollution;
- f) a baseline survey and the monitoring of the external environment; and
- g) the decommissioning and post-decommissioning of an installation or a pipe line.

Pre-Laying Consideration of the Instrument

In accordance with the established practice of the Committee, a pre-laying session was held with the technical team from the Ministry, led by Ms Suweibatu Adams and Officials of the Attorney General's Department to examine the draft instrument. The session afforded

the Committee the opportunity to offer recommendations for amendments prior to the formal laying of the Legislative Instrument on the floor of the House.

The pre-laying session provides a critical window for refining the instrument to ensure its alignment with national objectives and legal standards. This is because the 1992 Constitution does not permit modifications to a Legislative Instrument once laid before Parliament unless Parliament by a vote of not less than two-thirds of all Members, annul the Regulation before the expiration of twenty-one Sitting days.

Stakeholder Engagement

The Committee took note of the comprehensive report on stakeholder engagement held by the Authority to solicit contributions from key stakeholders. The Stakeholder meeting brought together key players in the oil and gas sector, including representatives from civil society organizations (CSOs). The purpose of the workshop was to review and deliberate on the draft Regulations as well as the newly developed Onshore Oil and Gas Guidelines.

The Committee applauds the efforts made at enriching the draft Legislative Instrument.

Observations

The Committee made the following observations during the deliberations:

Concerns Raised by the Petroleum Commission on Provisions of the Regulations

The Petroleum Commission raised concerns regarding specific provisions within the draft Regulations during the meeting. Their concerns focused on several key areas, including:

- The purpose and application of the Regulations
- National preparedness and response
- International co-operation in pollution response
- Application for environment permit
- Characterization of oil and gas

After thorough consideration, the Committee directed the Petroleum Commission and the Environmental Protection Authority (EPA) to engage in consultations aimed at reaching an agreement and to report back to the Committee.

Following a series of meetings between the parties, including discussions with the sector Minister, an agreement was reached. The agreed amendments were subsequently submitted to the Office of the Attorney General and Ministry of Justice for incorporation into the draft Regulations.

The Committee subsequently called for a second meeting on Tuesday, 22nd July, 2025 to ascertain whether the

outstanding issues were resolved between the parties.

Present at the meeting were Ms. Abena Ayensu, Acting Director of Legal, Ms. Veronica Amissah-Aidoo, Principal Legal Officer; and Eng. Jonathan Narh-Dometey from the Environmental Protection Authority. Representing the Petroleum Commission were Eng. Henry Mensah, Acting Director of Operations, Mr. William Anthony, Head of Gas and Facilities, Mr. Jeffery Kyei-Baffour, Head of Fiscal Metering and Instrumentation, Mr. Isaac Manu Owusu, Health, Safety, and Environmental Officer, as well as Legal Counsels Ms. Wisdom Amega Setsoafia, Ms. Grace Kumah-Madjie, and Ms. Samiratu Seidu.

The parties informed the Committee that all the outstanding matters had been fully resolved to their satisfaction and that the agreed amendments have been incorporated in the Draft Regulations.

Compliance with Law

The Committee is of the considered view that the Instrument satisfies the legal imperatives provided in article 11(7) of the 1992 Constitution, and does not contravene any provision of the Constitution, the parent Act or any other existing legislation.

In addition, the Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulations, 2025 does not impose any form of taxation. The Committee also notes that the Instrument contains no express provision authorizing expenditure from the Consolidated Fund or any other public funds.

Having considered the provisions of the Instrument, the Committee is of the opinion that the Instrument neither directly nor indirectly ousts the jurisdiction of the Courts, and it does not operate retrospectively to impose limitations on or adversely affect personal rights of persons.

Relevance of the Environmental Assessment Regulations, 1999 (L.I. 1652)

The Committee sought clarification on the continued relevance of the Environmental Assessment Regulations, 1999 (L.I. 1652) upon the coming into force of the new Regulations. The Committee expressed concern as to whether L.I. 1652 would become otiose. In response, the officials clarified that L.I. 1652 remains in force and continues to be legally binding until it is formally amended or revoked. They further explained that any future amendments to L.I. 1652 would have consequential implications for references made to it within the Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulations, 2025.

Flaring of Gas

The Committee observed that the Regulations provide a limited allowance for gas flaring by operators, and sought clarification on the rationale for this provision. It was explained that, during certain stages of the production process, it is technically challenging to capture and utilise the natural gas, necessitating controlled flaring. The Committee, while acknowledging these operational constraints, encouraged the officials to

implement measures that will maximise gas harvesting whenever feasible. Such efforts, the Committee noted, would significantly contribute to enhancing the country's energy production capacity.

Lack of Testing Laboratories in Ghana

The Committee observed that Ghana currently lacks laboratory facilities for the testing of chemicals with the potential to cause environmental pollution. This gap presents a significant challenge to the effective monitoring and regulation of environmental impacts, particularly within the petroleum sector. It was explained that the sector has not yet reached a level of maturity that would economically justify the substantial investment required to establish such facilities, given the high cost of the specialized equipment involved.

The Committee, therefore, recommends that the management of the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) explore the feasibility of establishing such laboratories through public-private partnership arrangements when conditions become favorable. This would serve to enhance the country's environmental monitoring capacity and support the long-term sustainable development of the petroleum sector.

Decision And Recommendation of the Committee

Having carefully examined the proposed Regulation aimed at establishing a clear and enforceable framework for licensing and regulating

petroleum-related activities. The Instrument promotes responsible operations by ensuring only qualified entities are permitted to operate, while enhancing accountability and transparency in the sector.

In view of these observations, the Committee, accordingly, recommends to the House to adopt its Report and endorse the coming into force the “**Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulations, 2025**: in accordance with Article 11(7) of the 1992 Constitution.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Motion moved, Report presented. Any seconder?

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question proposed

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, in the absence of any contribution?

Mr Nanja — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Sanja?

Mr Sanja Nanja (NDC — Atebubu/Amantin): Thank you, Mr Speaker. The Instruments were referred to us and we considered them. We realised that most of the Instruments were to empower and to operationalise the various Acts that were passed in respect of the Environmental Protection Authority and other Acts.

Thank you.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 11, Chairman of the Committee.

Suspension of Order 104 (1)

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That notwithstanding the provisions of Order 104(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that a Motion shall not be debated until at least two certain days have elapsed after the notice to move the Motion is given, the Motion for the adoption of the Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation under Public Private Partnership Regulations, 2025 may be *moved* today.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 12 — Motion.

Chairman of the Committee.

Report on the Public Private Partnership Regulations, 2025

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Public Private Partnership Regulations, 2025.

Mr Speaker, I ask the *Hansard* to capture the entire Report as having been presented.

Introduction

The Public Private Partnership Regulations, 2025 was laid by The Hon Minister responsible for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson on Thursday, 24th July, 2025 in accordance with Article 11(7) of the 1992 Constitution of Ghana and Order 100 of the Standing Orders of Parliament.

Pursuant to Order 220(3) of the Standing Orders, the Rt Hon Speaker referred the Instrument to the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation for consideration and report. The Committee met and deliberated on the referral and presents its Report to the House.

Committee's Deliberation

The Committee met and considered the Public Private Partnership Regulations, 2025. In attendance to consider and deliberate on the draft Instrument were the Acting Director for the Ministry of Finance, Mr Anthony Dzadzra, Coordinating Director of Ministry of Finance, Mr. David Klottey Collison, Head of Public Private Partnership Mr. Frederick Dartey and Officials from the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice.

The Committee expresses its profound gratitude to the Acting Director for the Ministry of Finance, Mr Anthony Dzadzra, the Coordinating Director of Ministry of Finance, Mr. David Klottey Collison, the Head of Public Private Partnership Frederick Dartey and Officials from the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice for attending upon the Committee to assist with the deliberations.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents during its deliberations:

The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;

The Standing Orders of Parliament of Ghana;

Public Private Partnership Act, 2020 (Act 1039); and

The Public Private Partnership Regulations, 2025.

The Scope of the Committee's Mandate

The Committee was guided by the provisions of article 11 (7) of the 1992 Constitution and Standing Order 220 (4) in considering the referral. These provisions enjoin the Committee to determine whether a Regulation under consideration: is in accordance with the Constitution or the Act under which it is made; contains any matter which should more appropriately be dealt with in an Act of Parliament; contains imposition of any tax; directly or indirectly bars the

jurisdiction of the courts; gives retrospective effect to any of the provisions in respect of which the Constitution or the Act does not expressly give that power; involves expenditure from the Consolidated Fund or public revenues; appears to make an unusual or unexpected use of powers conferred by the Constitution or the Act pursuant to which the Regulations were made; appears to have been unjustifiably delayed in its publication or in laying it before Parliament; and for any reason, in its form or purpose, requires clarification.

Background

In December 2020, the Parliament of Ghana enacted the Public-Private Partnership Act, 2020 (Act 1039), establishing a legal framework to support the development and implementation of Public-Private Partnership (PPP) projects across the country.

Following the passage of the Act, several key institutional milestones were achieved, including the establishment of various PPP institutional actors and the formation of PPP Committees responsible for approving projects and providing technical advisory support.

To ensure the continued effective and efficient implementation of PPP projects, the Ministry, in collaboration with the World Bank and the Office of the Attorney General and Ministry of Justice, developed the PPP Regulations. These Regulations will operationalize the Act by offering a comprehensive and standardized regulatory framework to guide the negotiation, execution, and oversight of PPP agreements.

Additionally, the enactment of the Regulations will enhance compliance among Contracting Authorities and other stakeholders by improving their understanding of the provisions of the principal Act and ensuring adherence to the procedural requirements of the PPP process.

It is therefore imperative that Parliament reviews and passes the PPP Agreement Regulations without delay, in order to fully give effect to the PPP Act, boost investor confidence, and advance Ghana's infrastructure development agenda.

Purpose of the Legislative Instrument

The purpose of these Regulations is to provide for: the obligations of the contracting authorities; the public private partnership process; the procedures for the application of the margin of preference for domestic business; the procedures for procurement through the Ghana Infrastructure Investment Fund; the procedures for unsolicited proposals or private sector led proposals; a complaints procedure; the management of the Project Development Facility and Viability Gap partnership project; the establishment and use of a special purpose entity for public private partnership project; contract management and amendment; early termination payments; transparency, disclosure and reporting obligations and accountability mechanisms; controls and limitations imposed on the regulated entity governed by the Act; and guidance on provisions to mainstream climate considerations into the different phases

of the public private partnership project cycle.

Pre-Laying Consideration of the Instrument

In accordance with the established practice of the Committee a pre-laying session was held with the Acting Director for the Ministry of Finance, Mr Anthony Dzadzra, Coordinating Director of Ministry of Finance, Mr. David Klottey Collison, Head of Public Private Partnership Mr. Frederick Dartey and other officers of the Ministry of Finance to examine the proposed Instrument. The session afforded the Committee the opportunity to offer recommendations for amendments prior to the formal laying of the Instrument.

The pre-laying session provides a critical window for refining the instrument to ensure its alignment with national objectives and legal standards. This is because the 1992 Constitution does not permit modifications to a Legislative Instrument once laid before Parliament, unless Parliament by a vote of not less than two-thirds of all Members annul the Regulation before the expiration of twenty-one Sitting days.

Stakeholder Engagement

The Committee acknowledged the comprehensive report presented by the Ministry on the stakeholder engagement process undertaken to gather input from key stakeholders. The engagement brought together representatives from contracting authorities, PPP institutional actors, Development Partners, civil

society organizations (CSOs), and consultancy firms. The primary objective of the workshop was to review and deliberate on the draft Regulations.

The Committee commends the Ministry and all participants for their valuable contributions toward enhancing the quality and substance of the draft Legislative Instrument.

Observations

In the course of its deliberations with officials from the Ministry of Finance, the Committee made the following observations:

Compliance with Law

The Committee is of the considered view that the Instrument satisfies the legal imperatives provided in article 11(7) of the 1992 Constitution, and does not contravene any provision of the Constitution, the Parent Act or any other existing legislation.

In addition, the Public Private Partnership Regulations, 2025 does not impose any form of taxation. The Committee also notes that the Instrument contains no express provision authorizing expenditure from the Consolidated Fund or any other public funds.

Having considered the provisions of the Instrument, the Committee is of the opinion that the Instrument neither directly nor indirectly ousts the jurisdiction of the Courts, and it does not operate retrospectively to impose limitations on or adversely affect personal rights of persons.

Potential Use of Arbitrary Power

The Committee sought clarification on Regulation 10(3)(a), which addresses conflict of interest. This provision states that a transaction advisor who has previously provided advisory services to a contracting authority shall not advise or assist a bidder participating in the procurement or implementation of the same PPP project. A breach of this provision may result in the advisor being blacklisted for a period determined by the designated Office.

The Committee raised concerns that this sub-regulation could be vulnerable to misuse by the designated Office, as defined in the Regulations. In response, it was clarified that the Office operates under the direct supervision of the Minister. Any exercise of the powers or discretion under this provision must receive prior approval from both the Minister and the Chief Director. This dual-approval mechanism is designed to prevent arbitrary or biased decision-making.

Operational Time Frame and Duration of PPP Agreements

The Committee sought clarification on the typical duration of a Public Private Partnership (PPP) agreement. It was explained that the duration largely depends on the scale of the investment and the projected cash flows, and that these timelines are specified within the terms of each individual contract agreement.

The Committee further recommended the development of a clearly defined operational time frame to guide the

implementation of PPP projects, and that such a framework be incorporated into the relevant operational guidelines.

Decision and Recommendation of the Committee

The Committee acknowledges that the full implementation of the PPP Act depends on the timely passage of its supporting Regulations. Approving these Regulations will therefore ensure clarity, strengthen investor confidence, and support Ghana's infrastructure development.

The Committee, accordingly, recommends to the House to adopt its Report and endorse the coming into force, the "**Public Private Partnership Regulations, 2025**" in accordance with Article 11(7) of the 1992 Constitution.

Respectfully submitted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Motion moved, Report presented. Any seconder?

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question proposed

Mr Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah (NPP — Manhyia South): Mr Speaker, the importance of the Public Private Partnership Act cannot be overemphasised. To implement or operationalise it, the Regulation is extremely necessary. The passage of these Regulations, Mr Speaker, would result in a major leap, particularly, in ensuring that the financing gap of major public infrastructural projects are met.

Mr Speaker, very respectfully, just as the Hon Chairman of the Committee said, this is going to be a major turnaround for financing within the public space, particularly, our infra-structural need. And so, Mr Speaker, I plead with the House to support this.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Sanja?

Mr Sanja Nanja (NDC — Atebubu/Amantin): The PPA Act, since it was passed, has not been very effective. So, this Instrument will be passed to operationalise it. And in this direction, the Ministry of Finance, in collaboration with the World Bank and the Office of the Attorney-General and the Ministry of Justice, developed these Regulations purposely to operationalise the PPP Act. And if we approve these Regulations, it will go a long way to enhance the compliance among collaborating authorities and other stakeholders.

We therefore urge the House to support the Motion and approve the instrument.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Now, the Motion numbered 13. Chairman of the Committee.

Suspension of Order 104 (1)

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That notwithstanding the provisions of Standing Order 104(1) of the

Standing Orders, which requires that a Motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the Motion is given, the Motion for the adoption of the Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Immigration Service (Amendment) Regulations, 2025 may be *moved* today.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): I second the Motion, Mr Speaker.

Question proposed.

Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, respectfully, we do not have copies.

3.47 p.m.

Mr Speaker, yesterday, you made a very important observation that when you are moving, we bring you back because we come to the Chamber and read the Reports as it is being laid. It is not helping, especially those of us who are new and I have been consistent with this matter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do we read Reports during Procedural Motions?

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, no, but it has been laid.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What is the issue at stake? Which Motion are we taking?

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, once the Report has been laid—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Which Motion are we taking? Is it not Motion numbered 13?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Report has been duly presented and distributed about a week ago. It was even on our console. So, I will talk to my Colleague to let him understand and this one was even procedural—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but at the end of the day, let us get the process right. When a procedural Motion is moved, no Report is required. So, why would you be demanding a Report at the time that we are taking a procedural Motion?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, my Colleague was seeking clarification. I will engage him, so we can proceed.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Now, let us take the Substantive Motion numbered 14.

MOTION

Immigration Service (Amendment) Regulations, 2025

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Immigration Service (Amendment) Regulations, 2025.

Mr Speaker, I will urge that the *Hansard* captures the entire Report as having been read, while I read the conclusion and recommendations of the Committee.

Introduction

The Immigration Service (Amendment) Regulations, 2025 was laid by the Hon Minister for the Interior, Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka, on the 17th July, 2025 in accordance with article 11(7) of the 1992 Constitution of Ghana and Order 100 of the Standing Orders of Parliament.

Pursuant to Order 220(3) of the Standing Orders, the Rt Hon Speaker referred the Instrument to the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation for consideration and Report. The Committee met and deliberated on the referral and presents its Report to the House.

Deliberations

The Committee met and considered the Immigration Service (Amendment) Regulations, 2025. In attendance to consider and deliberate on the draft Instrument were Ms Doreen Annan, the Acting Chief Director of the Ministry of the Interior; Deputy Commissioner of Immigration (DCOI), Evelyn Lotsu (Financial Controller); Assistant Commissioner of Immigration (ACOI) and Acting Deputy Comptroller-General, Legal, Research and Monitoring, Philip Peter Andoh; and other officers of the Ghana Immigration Service, as well as officials from the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice.

The Committee expresses its profound gratitude to the acting Chief Director of the Ministry of the Interior, the Financial Controller, the acting Deputy Comptroller-General, Legal Research and Monitoring, and all other officers of the Ghana Immigration Service as well as officials from the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice for attending upon the Committee to assist with the deliberations.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents during its deliberations:

- a. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;
- b. The Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana;
- c. The Immigration Service Act (Act 908);
- d. The Immigration Service Regulations, 2016 (L.I. 2245); and
- e. The Immigration Service (Amendment) Regulations, 2025.

The Scope of the Committee's Mandate

The Committee was guided by the provisions of article 11(7) of the 1992 Constitution and Standing Order 220(4) in considering the referral. These provisions enjoin the Committee to determine whether a Regulation under consideration:

- a. is in accordance with the Constitution or the Act under which it is made;
- b. contains any matter which should more appropriately be dealt with in an Act of Parliament;
- c. contains imposition of any tax;
- d. directly or indirectly bars the jurisdiction of the courts;
- e. gives retrospective effect to any of the provisions in respect of which the Constitution or the Act does not expressly give that power;
- f. involves expenditure from the Consolidated Fund or public revenues;
- g. appears to make an unusual or unexpected use of powers conferred by the Constitution or the Act pursuant to which the Regulations were made;
- h. appears to have been unjustifiably delayed in its publication or in laying it before Parliament; and
- i. for any reason, in its form or purpose, requires clarification.

Background

The Immigration Service (Amendment) Regulations, 2025 is being enacted to support the effective implementation of the Immigration Service Act, 2016 (Act 908), and also guide the operations of the Immigration Service concerning terms

and conditions of service of retirees of the Immigration Service.

The Minister for the Interior, by section 30 of the Immigration Service Act, 2016 (Act 908), is empowered to make regulations to give effect to the Act. Section 30 of the Act stipulates that the Minister may, on the advice of the Ghana Immigration Council, by Legislative Instrument, make Regulations for carrying out or giving effect to the Act, including the terms and conditions of service of officers and employees of the Service.

The amendment Regulations is, therefore, necessary to enhance the operationalisation of the provisions of Act 908. The amendments are founded on the need to ensure that officers who serve the nation diligently are adequately compensated upon retirement.

Purpose of the Legislative Instrument

The Instrument aims to provide clarity, fairness, and consistency in the administration of pensions and gratuities of the Ghana Immigration Service by the amendment of Regulations 109, 110 and 111 of the Immigration Service Regulations, 2016. (L. I. 2245). It also seeks to outline a fair, transparent, and structured approach to pension and gratuity benefits for all officers of the Service.

Pre-Laying Consideration of the Instrument

In accordance with the established practice of the Committee, a pre-laying session was held with the acting Chief

Director of the Ministry of the Interior, Ms Doreen Annan; the acting Chief Director of the Ministry of the Interior, the Financial Controller, DCOI Evelyn Lotsu; and the acting Deputy Comptroller-General, Legal, Research and Monitoring, ACOI Philip Peter Andoh; and other officers of the Ghana Immigration Service to examine the proposed Instrument. The session afforded the Committee the opportunity to offer recommendations for amendments prior to the formal laying of the Instrument.

The pre-laying session provides a critical window for refining the instrument to ensure its alignment with national objectives and legal standards. This is because the 1992 Constitution does not permit modifications to a Legislative Instrument once laid before Parliament, unless Parliament, by a vote of not less than two-thirds of all Members, annul the Regulation before the expiration of twenty-one Sitting days.

Observations

In the course of its deliberations with officials from the Ministry and the Immigration Service, the Committee made the following observations:

Amendment to Regulation 109 on Retirement Benefits

The Committee observed that Regulation 109 of the Immigration Service Regulations, 2016 (L. I. 2245), previously provided that officers who had attained the voluntary or compulsory retirement age in accordance with article

199(1) and (2) of the 1992 Constitution were to be paid gratuities and pensions recommended by the Ghana Immigration Service Council, subject to the discretionary approval of the Government.

This provision has now been amended to enhance clarity and fairness in the administration of retirement benefits. The revised Regulation 109 now ensures that gratuity and pension benefits for both voluntary and compulsory retirees of the Ghana Immigration Service are in accordance with recommendations made by the Ghana Immigration Service Council and a new formula introduced under the substituted Regulation 110 of the same L. I. 2245.

Standardised Formula for Calculation of Pensions & Gratuity

The Committee also observed that Regulation 110 of L. I. 2245 had been substituted to introduce a comprehensive and standardised formula for the calculation of pension and gratuity for officers of the Service. This replaces the previous approach, which left the determination of such benefits solely to the discretion of the Government.

The newly introduced formula provides clear criteria for determining full pension and gratuity entitlements. It considers the officer's total length of service in months, the consolidated annual salary corresponding to the officer's rank at retirement, and a fixed pension. Additionally, it specifies the applicable gratuity rate and clearly defines the components of the

consolidated annual salary to be used for calculation purposes.

Monthly Pension Entitlements for Senior & Junior Officers

It was observed that Regulation 111 of the Immigration Service Regulations, 2016 (L. I. 2245) has been revised to clearly establish the monthly pension entitlements for officers of the Service based on rank. Under the revised Regulations, senior officers from the rank of Assistant Commissioner and above are entitled to a monthly pension equivalent to their consolidated monthly salary. In contrast, officers of the rank of Chief Superintendent and below are entitled to receive 80 per cent of their consolidated monthly salary as monthly pension. This revision introduces a structured and equitable approach to pension benefits across all ranks in the Service.

Conclusion and Recommendation

The Committee acknowledges that the enactment of the Immigration Service (Amendment) Regulations, 2025 is essential to promote morale of staff and ensure the financial security for officers of the Ghana Immigration Service after retirement. The amendments to the Immigration Service Regulations, 2016 will mark a significant step towards enhancing the welfare of retirees of the Service, thereby serving as a motivational measure for officers in active service.

The Committee, accordingly, recommends to the House to adopt its Report and endorse the coming into

force, the “Immigrations Service (Amendment) Regulations, 2025” in accordance with Article 11(7) of the 1992 Constitution.

Mr Speaker, the Committee acknowledges that the enactment of the Immigration Service Amendment Regulations, 2025 is essential to promote morale of staff and ensure the financial security for officers of the Ghana Immigration Service after retirement. The amendments to the Immigration Service Regulations, 2016 will mark a significant step towards enhancing the welfare of retirees of the Service, thereby serving as a motivational measure for officers in active service. The Committee accordingly recommends to the House to adopt its report and endorse the coming into force of the Immigration Service (Amendment) Regulations 2025 in accordance with Article 11(7) of the Constitution.

Respectfully submitted.

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question proposed.

Mr Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu (NDC — Madina): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I rise to speak in favour of the Motion ably moved by the Chairman of the Committee and to add that this Regulation is, indeed, long overdue. At the deliberation stage, it came out so clearly that the non-passage of this Regulation has led to a number of tension situation within the Immigration Service and that resolving this matter

through the passage of this Regulation was going to definitely increase both the effectiveness, the confidence and efficiency of workers in the Immigration Service.

Mr Speaker, so I pray that this House adopts and supports this Motion ably moved by the Chairman.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I rise to contribute to support the Motion that has just been ably moved by Hon Patrick Boamah.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, take note. Next time, at the time that you are seconding the Motion, you make your contribution after seconding, but go ahead.

Mr Shaib: Very well; I am guided.

Mr Speaker, the Immigration officers around Ghana have been very supportive in ensuring that our borders are safe. Sometimes, they do their job at the peril of their lives. If you come to my constituency, Weija-Gbawe, I anticipate the commander there may be going on retirement soon. Such a person should have some security of tenure and should not be thinking of his welfare after service. That is why I commend the Committee for taking into consideration issues that border on their gratuities after work or their pension entitlements.

Mr Speaker, I want to say that this is a good move. It is a step that is in the right direction and we commend the Committee Members and the House. Thank you very much for this opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, any further contributions?

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader, do we now come back to the item numbered 8?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered eight, Motion. It is now the turn of—

Yes, Hon Habib?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I know that, this morning, the Majority Leader has been rehearsing his notes for this all-important closing of the debate on the Mid-Year Budget Review and I want to encourage Colleagues that we should be very quiet and listen to our Leaders in silence as they have 45 minutes each to deliver or conclude on their message. Majority Leader, I said 45 minutes because the Business Committee Report that was adopted had in it 45 minutes and it was 45 minutes that was approved.

So, I just want to urge Colleagues that we on this Side will be quiet to listen to both Leaders and I urge my Colleagues to be quiet and listen to our Leaders in silence because the Majority Leader has been reading since last night until this morning and he continues to read—*[Interruption]*—I was with him this morning, even before Conclave and I saw that he was reading. The papers that he was reading were more than 100,000. *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is a very legitimate concern. Our Leaders are coming to conclude the debate on the Mid-Year Budget Review. I will urge both Sides to listen to the Leaders in silence. Failure to do that, Hon Members, the Rules strictly would be applied.

I will proceed to give the floor to the Hon Minority Leader, Togbe Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin. You have 45 minutes and the floor is now yours.

MOTION

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025.

[Resumption of Debate from Wednesday, 30/07/25]

3.57 p.m.

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, when you addressed me, Togbe, you reminded me of my grandpa.

You know, when we were young in Nyekonakpoe, he had this song; it just struck me. I do not know if you remember that song:

[The Hon Member sang an Ewe song]

Mr Speaker, Colleagues, Hon Majority Leader, today, it is our turn, the Minority, to conclude our Side of the debate and I rise to fulfil two solemn duties. First, to expose the glaring falsehoods in Hon Ato Forson's spreadsheet, a document riddled with

misleading figures designed to obscure the truth. Second, to give voice to the millions of Ghanaians who have been betrayed by broken promises and abandoned dreams.

Seven months ago, this Government pledged a new beginning, a reset for our nation. Yet, what have the people received? Not renewal, but ruin. Not progress, but economic wreckage dressed in empty rhetoric. So, Mr Speaker, I stand here to speak the truth to power, to a Government that has lost its moral compass, deserted its commitment and systematically broken the trust of 33 million citizens. The evidence is undeniable and this is not merely a Government in crisis; it is a Government in collapse because it is not facing the truth.

Mr Speaker, the Mid-Year Budget Review before us reads like a confession of failure. As my Colleagues before me have copiously pointed out, behind every projection lies a story of incompetence. Behind every statistic, we find the reality of a nation bleeding from self-inflicted wounds.

Mr Speaker, while the Bank of Ghana announces fairy tale exchange rate, businesses desperate for foreign currency cannot access a single dollar from our banking system. They are forced into the shadows of black markets, where reality bears no resemblance to government fiction. This artificial exchange rate manipulation has crippled legitimate importers, destroyed business confidence and turned our economy into a house of cards.

The Minister proudly reports a custom revenue shortfall of GHC1.6 billion, blaming smuggling, but Mr Speaker, he cannot collect revenue on goods that are never imported because businesses cannot access foreign exchange to finance legitimate trade. This Government has created an economic environment where legal commerce becomes impossible, while illegal activities flourish. Perhaps, the most damning indictment lies in their own projections. They say they are competent. This Government inherited an economy growing at 5.7 per cent and now, projects a 4 per cent growth. How does competence deliver the 1.7 percentage point decline? How does change deliver dis-regression?

Mr Speaker, when a Government inherits economic momentum and kills it in seven months, they have not just failed; they have sabotaged the future of the country. When the Minister declares: "I am not asking for additional money", he confesses that the Government has no ideas, no vision and no capacity to accelerate growth. They are undertakers, disguised as economists, managing economic funeral of Ghana, while calling it fiscal policy.

Mr Speaker, let me remind this House of what Ghana once had and what these self-proclaimed apostles of research have systematically destroyed. We built robust diplomatic relations with strategic partners at the United States of America (USA), strengthening the position of Ghana in the global market.

The apostles of reset have assassinated these partnerships with

reckless, undiplomatic utterances that are gradually making Ghana a barrier in international circles. We initiated a transformational One District One Factory (1D1F) to create jobs and boost local production across every corner of Ghana. The apostles of reset have murdered this industrial revolution and condemned these initiatives to economic stagnation.

We launched the Agenda 111 hospitals to heal our people and create a foundation for medical tourism. The apostles of reset have killed this health infrastructure expansion, leaving communities without hope for quality health care.

Mr Speaker, we pioneered Planting for Food and Jobs (PFJ) to feed our people, to ensure food security and create agricultural wealth. The so-called apostles of reset have slaughtered this agricultural transformation, leaving farmers abandoned and food security compromised.

All they know is the Gold Board to promote *galamsey* and it came without doubt, that on May Day, Organised Labour, without relenting, boldly confronted this issue and questioned the commitment of the Government in dealing with *galamsey*. Organised Labour, speaking through its Secretary General, said that *galamsey* within the first five months of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Administration has worsened. The NDC has not questioned.

Mr Speaker, recently, we had the Catholic Bishops' Conference also

coming out with a strongly worded statement, pointing to the worsening *galamsey* situation. All because the Government has now legitimised the *galamsey* menace and the Gold Board now buys and encourages people to pursue *galamsey*.

Mr Speaker, without doubt, we also established rigorous prosecution to recover stolen national resources and reinvest recovered funds into national development. Today, what do we see? The Government is now using *nolle prosequi* to protect its financiers and are rather persecuting New Patriotic Party (NPP) appointees.

Mr Speaker, with 30 per cent of youth unemployed, this Government has allocated only GHC0.5 billion to create jobs, a pittance that insult 3 million unemployed young Ghanaians. When young people have no stake in the legitimacy of the economy, they become recruits for criminal gangs and illegal mining operations. There is a direct correlation between this Government failure to create jobs and the unprecedented insecurity plaguing our nation. Every unemployed youth represents not just wasted potential, but a security threat borne of economic neglect.

Mr Speaker, over 1,500 Ghanaians, the reports have it, have perished on our roads since January till date. The Kumasi Highway has become a graveyard because this Government refuses to pay contractors. Mr Speaker, even Ministries, their allocations have not been released, how much more contractors? None of the Ministers can

boldly say on record that he or she has received releases. Mr Speaker, every pothole represents lost productivity. Every death on our highways bears the fingerprint of this Government. The contractors must be paid and paid now.

Mr Speaker, perhaps, let me remind the NDC that long before they assumed office in 2009 and long after they had lost power in 2000, the eight years of the Kufuor Administration, established the following social intervention programmes that are still part of the governance of the country. These were the legacies of President John Agyekum Kufuor: the School Feeding Programme; the Capitation Grant; the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS) that the NDC shamelessly boycotted the passage of the law; the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP); free maternal care, free busing for pupils, and he established the Metro Mass Transit System, which became known as the Kufuor Bus.

4.07 p.m.

Mr Speaker, today, we see the NDC seven months in office, and they have not come out with any productive social intervention programme to give hope to the Ghanaian people. We therefore demand that they restore economic sanity through transparent foreign exchange options, expand the Gold for Oil Reserve programme, and eliminate artificial exchange rate manipulation. We also demand of them, through their Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry, to reinstate the IDIF programme to create opportunities for businesses.

On the Agenda 111 hospitals, they have to continue to let these hospitals be completed. Again, instead of relying on *galamsey* activity as a way of growing the economy, they should restore agricultural transformation.

Mr Speaker, the Government must also strengthen diplomatic relations with strategic partners, restore impartial justice, pay contractors promptly, and create a safe environment for business and investment. I need to repeat here, illegal mining is going on, and it is affecting our nation. The time has come for this Government to rise to the occasion and walk the talk to protect our environment.

Mr Speaker, we, the Minority, have a duty to set the record straight, and we will systematically dismantle the misleading claims and omissions in the Minister's presentation. Using facts and historical context, we will demonstrate how many of their touted achievements in the last six months are either a continuation of the policies laid down by the previous NPP Administration or simply unearned credits claimed by the new Government. We cannot allow false narratives to take root; Ghanaians deserve the truth about our fiscal health, inflation trends, currency stability, employment situation, social programmes, debt management, and taxation policies.

I need to remind them that upon assuming office, a directive was issued by the Chief of Staff, which led to thousands of jobs being lost. Many Ghanaian youth who had been employed were sacked, and an attempt to raise the matter on the floor of the House was

resisted by the Majority. Mr Speaker, let us be clear, the story of Ghana from 2017 to 2024 was one of significant progress, and though tough decisions had to be taken amidst global and domestic challenges, we all saw that within half a year, the NDC blamed the NPP for all economic woes, yet took credit for the groundwork laid before.

Mr Speaker, we would address the major claim in turn, exposing again the inconsistency, highlighting the true drivers of Ghana's recent economic development. Mr Speaker, the Mid-Year Budget Review attempted to paint the former NPP Government as fiscally reckless, citing "balloon deficit" arrears of US\$6 billion in unpaid bills and US\$194 billion in contract commitment. Yes, Ghana's deficit did spike in 2020 we admit, but context matters. A global pandemic forced emergency expenditures and a banking sector clean-up to protect millions of depositors. These were extraordinary interventions, not wanton profligacy. If that money that they claim today is 60-40 had not been pursued, where would Ghana be? They messed up the economy and messed up the banking sector. The billions that went to their financiers which they could not take steps to protect, today, they claim that we messed up the economy. The evidence is there, and they have exposed themselves. "60-40" is what they are called on the streets of Accra; it is their new name. "Give me 60, take 40" is their new name.

In fact, Mr Speaker, the NPP Government reduced the deficit sharply upon taking office, from 9.3 per cent of

GDP in 2016, down to about 6 per cent in 2017, and kept it near 5 per cent through 2019. The 2020 deficit of 17 per cent of GDP was a one-off crisis response mirrored worldwide, which saved lives and jobs. It is disingenuous for the Minister for Finance to label that life-saving effort as reckless spending. Let us also correct the record on Ghana's public debt and the claim of alleged insolvency. It is true that debt to GDP rose under NPP. No doubt, we admit; from 56 per cent in 2016 to around 80 per cent in 2022. But what drove this? We inherited significant legacy costs, such as the energy sector debt from their take-or-pay. They did not analyse a contract, they did not scrutinise, and they signed a take-or-pay contract and left it for a new government to inherit. These power contracts that were signed under the previous administration hit the economy, and it was a drain on public purse. I challenge them to rise to rebut this.

We also weathered the external shocks. COVID-19 borrowing to cushion the economy and steep cedi depreciation as global investors pulled back, and they know that. Crucially, we put those borrowed funds to productive use; investing in education infrastructure, they left their e-blocks, and we completed them. [**Some Hon Members: Ei!**] Industry and social programmes that benefit Ghanaians today. If the state's finances were strained, it was in the course of building for the future and cleaning up the mess, not to wanton waste.

Moreover, Mr Speaker, we took responsibility for top reforms to address

debt issues. We initiated the IMF-supported recovery programme in 2022 and undertook a painful domestic debt exchange programme. They lambasted us on this. We paid a high price. We are in opposition. But today, that painful decision that came at a cost to us is what they are relying on to build the economy. Can they deny that?

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance boasted that our debt-to-GDP ratio is at a five-year low and that the public debt dropped by GH¢113.7 billion in six months. Mr Speaker, this is very misleading. The reality, however, is that no significant amount of debt has been paid off by this Government. The statistical drop in debt ratio is largely due to the debt cancellation and restructuring achieved under the previous Government, combined with the cedi's appreciation effect. We asked the Minister, exactly how much of Ghana's public debt this Government has repaid to claim credit for the reduction. The answer is inconvenient; virtually none.

Ghana's debt improved because the NPP did the heavy lifting, including a historic external debt operation that achieved US\$5 billion outright debt forgiveness and US\$ 4.7 billion in debt service savings. That is real debt reduction. The current Administration merely stepped into an improving situation which was engineered by its predecessors.

Mr Speaker, to further buttress this point, let us recall that under NPP's stewardship, Ghana never defaulted on external debt until the 2022 crisis hit at the tail end of our term. We consistently

met debt service obligations until an unprecedented combination of events forced a brief halt. Even then, the NPP swiftly devised a solution, the Energy Sector Levy Act, to systematically pay down energy liability, a fiscal responsibility law, capping deficits at 5 per cent of GDP to instil discipline, and the debt exchange to restore sustainability. These are actions of responsible government, and we are proud we took such decisions, not a reckless one.

The Mid-Year Budget Review blasts our administration for high debt but conveniently omits that by the end of 2024, Ghana's debt to GDP had actually fallen to about 70.5 per cent. This decline was the fruit of the painful haircut and fiscal adjustment we undertook to reset the economy. Again, we take responsibility, we say sorry to Ghanaians, we had to take a painful decision to implement this, but they are taking advantage of these painful decisions without giving credit to us. Who is the hypocrite in this matter?

4.17 p.m.

They are the ones who are found wanting, and indeed, they are the political naysayers; they engage in double standard and political hypocrisy.

In short, the New Patriotic Party (NPP) cleaned up a grave situation and now the new administration touts the cleaner floor as if it were their own accomplishment. What have they put in place? None.

Mr Speaker, let us address the narrative of wasteful spending under the NPP. The Minister derided the former

Government's expenditure as waste, yet we recall vividly that in 2020 the same National Democratic Congress (NDC) was loud calling for a greater expenditure on COVID-19 related activities to alleviate hardship. They said so in this very Chamber. They talk of debt unsustainability today but their solution so far has been to go back to the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and rely on new borrowing under stricter condition. The truth is that, the NPP invested in Ghana's future. We rolled out transformational policies like the Free SHS, build roads; 13,000 kilometres of roads—[Uproar]—across the country and initiated the One District One Factory (1D1F) to stimulate economic growth.

Mr Speaker, those investments are yielding dividends for our people. Meanwhile, the current Government enjoys an IMF lifeline and fiscal space created by NPP's difficult reforms. They should be thanking the previous administration and not lambasting it.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance boasts that inflation has plunked from 23.8 per cent in December 2024 to 13.7 per cent by June 2025, implying some miraculous stabilisation by the new administration. Ghana's inflation story requires a longer length. Yes, inflation is down from its peak and that is good news for everyone, but we must remember why inflation spiked in the first place and how this trend was already reversing before January 2025. The reality check is that, Ghana's inflation soared in 2022, peaked at over 50 per cent year-on-year by December 2022, the highest in 22 years. This was not because of domestic

fiscal indiscipline. It was largely imported pain, global supply shocks, COVID-19-induced supply chain disruptions, a surge in international oil prices, and the Russia- Ukraine war impact on food and fuel. —[Uproar]—

Mr Speaker, if this claim, by us will not shift, if this claim by us is unacceptable to our Colleagues who are now in Government, then I ask, why did President John Dramani Mahama recently say that the situation in Middle East would have effect on the economy? Therefore, he is inviting the Minister for Finance and the Minister for Energy and Green Transition to sit together to review certain government policies. If international shocks have no effect, why did the President complain that the Middle East crisis is having an effect on the economy? What a shame.

Mr Speaker, we saw transport fares up, we saw the price of imported foods going up, and civil prices surge worldwide. Ghana, being a small open economy, could not escape this wave.

Mr Speaker, the Minister's own figure of 23.8 per cent in December 2024 reflect this progress. To put this in perspective, pre-crisis inflation on the NPP was lowest in decades. We ended 2019 at just 7.9 per cent inflation, while within single digits. So, while 13.7 per cent in June 2025 is certainly much improved from the height of 2022, which we admit, it is not some unprecedented four-year low, as the Minister suggests. In fact, it is higher than what we achieved in normal times before the global crisis and what has changed in 2025? The sharp disinflation in the first half of

2025? It is largely a continuation of the trend that NPP set in motion under the IMF programme and our economic recovery policies. We stabled fuel prices globally, and the cedi regaining some strength. Prices of imported goods began to ease. The Minister himself admits that the recent inflation drop, quote, “is not by chance or sheer luck”. Indeed, this was by design or policies that began under the Nana Addo Dankwah Akufo-Addo’s Government.

Mr Speaker, it was NPP that negotiated the IMF support package, which restored investor confidence and unlocked funding. It was NPP that started the Gold for Oil Programme to moderate fuel prices, and it was NPP’s fiscal adjustment that rained in excess liquidity. But to claim sole credit or trumpet as a vindication of six-months work is premature. Ghana’s inflation was already coming down, and the global condition provided a tailwind. There has been no bold new anti-inflation strategy from the current Government beyond sticking with the IMF guided path set earlier. Let us also recall Ghana’s longer inflation history for this House.

Mr Speaker, under the previous NDC Government, that is 2012 to 2016, inflation was often run in mid-teens and even surpassed 17 per cent. At one point, Ghana faced hyper-inflationary pressures. Indeed, going back further, we had over 40 per cent inflation in 2000 and had to re-dominate the Cedi in 2007 due to cumulative high inflation eroding the currency’s value. In the year 2000, the Government in power was their party; it was NDC, and they took us to a

40 per cent inflation. Now, those storms are passing. Inflation is naturally receding. The NDC cannot credibly claim to have fixed the inflation in six months, when the truth is that Ghana was already healing. We caution that the 13 per cent inflation is still higher than our pre-crisis norm. There is more work ahead to bring it fully into the single-digit target band. That work requires consistency, prudence, not celebratory lapses after just half a year. I urge the Minister for Finance to release monies to the Ministers. The Ministers are idle; the Ministers are not working. Release their allocations to them. Pay the contractors.

Mr Speaker, the Mid-Year Review makes much of the Ghanaian cedi’s performance. With the Minister jubilantly declaring, *Cedi no apicki* he even claimed the recent Cedi appreciation has never happened in the history of the country.

Mr Speaker, let us analyse this carefully. It is true that in the first part of 2025, the Cedi strengthened against major currencies and undoubtedly positive development, and we admit. But what are the underlining causes and is it sustainable, I ask? First, context of 2022 must be highlighted. Yes, the Cedi was one of the world’s worst performing currencies that year, depreciating steeply, at one point losing over half of its value. It is a matter of public record. But again, this did not occur in isolation; I dare argue. In 2022, virtually all emerging economies fell short sharply against a surging US dollar. Emerging economies and their currencies fell short of the US dollar. Several Federal Reserve

aggressive rate hikes made the dollar strong in decades. As I have already mentioned, the Ukraine conflict drove oil and commodity imports costs up, sucking foreign exchange out of countries like ours. Ghana also faced a momentary loss of investor confidence before the IMF deal, which hurt forex inflows. In short, the 2022 was a storm for the Cedi, and I concede.

4.27 p.m.

But I dare argue that despite all of these, the NPP Government stabilised the cedi in 2023. After reaching its weakest point in late 2022, the cedi slide was arrested and partially reversed. The key was restoring confidence, securing the International Monetary Fund (IMF) agreement in 2023, commencing the debt restructuring, which signaled to markets that Ghana was addressing its debt and innovative policies like the gold for oil, where we battered gold for fuel to reduce forex demands. By the end of 2024, the cedi depreciation had slowed dramatically. It was down only by 19 per cent year-on-year against the dollar, a marked improvement from the free-for-all earlier. So, when the new Government took over the reins of affairs in January 2025, they inherited a stabilising currency, not a perpetually dwindling one.

Mr Speaker, now the cedi's appreciation in 2025. Indeed, from January through to June, the cedi strengthened significantly which the Minister tout as unprecedented. We do welcome a stronger cedi. We on this Side welcome a stronger cedi. It eases the

burden on import costs and brings some price relief to Ghanaians. However, claiming this as a proof of some unique NDC prowess is misleading. Several factors have contributed to the cedi's rise, and they are not purely the result of fresh political genius. A major factor is renewed investor confidence and inflows on the back of the IMF Programme and improved fiscal outlook; a trajectory set in motion last year. Another factor is Ghana's record high gold exports and remittances in late 2024.

Mr Speaker, let me remind the NDC, whereas they have denied the successes of NPP in laying the foundation, they have quietly indicated that in their Report to the IMF. That is why recently, the IMF exposed them, that they have acknowledged that the stability they find today is as a result of the foundation laid by the Akufo-Addo Government. Why did they refuse to acknowledge it in the despatch box, but rather wrote a letter to the IMF to admit this? — **[Some Hon Members: Where is the letter?]** —

Mr Speaker, these inflows from the IMF shored up our reserves. By the end of 2024, Ghana's gross international reserve stood at US\$8.9 billion, a healthy buffer, well ahead of IMF targets. The Minister during the Mid-Year Review proudly announced that the reserves have further risen to US\$11.12 billion by June, 2025. What he failed to clarify was that the US\$8.9 billion of that was inherited from the previous administration's efforts. The new addition in the first half of 2025 was just about US\$2.2 billion—significant, yes,

but not miraculous, given the favourable trade winds and carryover programmes.

Crucially, Mr Speaker, the Bank of Ghana's heavy intervention in the forex market has played an unsustainable role in propping up the cedi, and this the IMF has pointed out, yet they are quiet. Despite earlier denial, it took the IMF to reveal that the first quarter of 2025 alone, the Bank of Ghana (BoG) injected US\$1.4 billion of reserves into the market to support the cedi. Have they told Ghanaians this? Was this included in their Mid-Year Report? This kind of artificial support, effectively using scarce reserves to boost the cedi, can only be a short-term strategy.

Indeed, the IMF has cautioned our Government about the sustainability of this approach, urging that we reduce the BoG's footprint and allow greater exchange rate flexibility going forward. On the ground, many importers and businesses will tell you a sobering truth. While the official interbank rate has shown a strong cedi, dollars have become scarce in the open market; a wide arbitrage has emerged. The cedi appears stronger on paper, but it is difficult for businesses to actually obtain forex at those rates. As one of my Colleagues, aptly put it, "*cedi no apicki, but Abokyi has the dollar.*" The point is that, the real economic strength comes from a currency's purchasing power and not just the exchange rate on a given day. This Government must hear this.

Mr Speaker, in contrast, consider the currency stability under the NPP's first term, that is from 2017 to 2019. During

that period, the cedi's annual depreciation averaged around 8 to 10 per cent. A remarkably stable performance compared to the 18 to 30 per cent annual slides seen in the previous NDC era of 2012 to 2016. There were even stretches where the cedi was one of Africa's more stable currencies under Akufo-Addo's Administration. We achieved this through discipline, fiscal management, and innovative schemes like forward forex auctions and improved exports. It was only when external crisis hit that the cedi wobbled, and when it did, NPP was innovative.

Mr Speaker, let me now turn to their so-called 24-Hour Economy. They claim that they have introduced something they call the 24-Hour Economy. They have touted it as a transformational plan to run Ghana's economy around the clock, spanning its pillar from Grow 24 to Connect 24. On paper, it promises 1.7 million jobs in four years and a productivity reboot. However, Mr Speaker, this rhetoric of a nation that Ghana never sleeps, collides with Ghana's own on-ground realities. Few African cities truly operate 24/7, and Accra is nowhere near New York or Dubai. What we expect is for the Government to make investments in the private sector, but there are no such signs. All they know is to focus on promoting *galamsey*. Tripling daily operating hours in key sectors sounds impressive, but visibility is questionable. Ghana's economy cannot be whirled into a 24-hour cycle by slogan. It requires concrete capacity that currently seems lacking. There is a lack that this grand vision remains largely rhetorical, with

little change on the factory floor or the farm gate beyond normal business hours.

A glaring weakness of this 24-Hour Economy Programme is its heavy reliance on financing that may never fully materialise. The initiative cost is pegged at around US\$4 billion, yet Government is only committing US\$300 to US\$400 million as seed capital. The rest is expected from the private sector, a lofty assumption in Ghana's current climate. But I dare ask, what are the incentives for the private sector? A situation where instead of creating jobs, they are sacking our youth from having their jobs. Then they say that they are creating jobs. What foundation are they mounting this vision on?

Mr Speaker, this country must not be subjected to public relations (PR) gimmicks and political rhetorics. We want action and the NDC must know that the clock is ticking; we do not have time. Out of their four years, almost seven months is gone; time is not on their side. They must do something before the people boot them out.

Mr Speaker, even if money is found, the implementation bottlenecks abound. A 24-Hour Economy needs reliable 24-hour power supply. Do we have a reliable power supply? Since they came, *dumsor* is what we see. The Minority has suggested to this Government to pursue reforms at the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG). Reforms were started, they should pursue and we will support them. What they are doing instead is to come out with new levies because that is a convenient way. We want to tell them that if they are serious about this 24-Hour

Economy, their duty is to undertake reforms and focus on agriculture. What they are doing will take them nowhere. They cannot continue to impose levies. At ECG, they started with 14 per cent and then ended with another 2.7 per cent.

4.37 p.m.

Then they came with another *dumsor* levy, all in an attempt to resolve the crisis, yet they have abandoned the key thing to pursue, which is a reform. Are they serious or they are still in rhetoric?

Mr Speaker, now they claim a certain Big Push—And they have selected certain roads that they claim will be constructed. We wish them well. However uneven we found these to be, at least, we want to give them the chance. Let us see how they roll them out in the next six months.

Mr Speaker, we call on the NDC to acknowledge the investment that were made in the educational sector. Happily, Dr Adutwum is in this Chamber. They should acknowledge the investment made by him and Dr Matthew Opoku Prempeh as sector Ministers in the Ministry of Education. Not only did we roll out Free Senior High School (Free SHS), we also came up with Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET), made sure that the TVET was free and also introduced a Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics (STEM) programme—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, you may have to—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, just address the Chair.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well.

Mr Speaker, to date, over 3.1 million Ghanaian students have benefited from the Free SHS; they have gained access to education, a thing that many Ghanaian youths never dreamt of. The NPP must be commended. We would want to conclude by urging the NDC that they have an opportunity to govern, so they should focus on governance. They should create a Ghana that is an opportunity for all, stop hounding the Chief Justice and politicising the Judiciary, focus on a Ghana that will be attractive for all, focus on a Ghana that all of us will be proud to be citizens of and they should not think that the power they have will last forever. The power they have is left with three and a half years.

Mr Speaker, we have had our chance, made our mistakes, chalked successes and admit that we could not have been perfect. But the expectation is that they who said they could do it better should do it better for all to see.

Mr Speaker, that said and without more, I would want to thank you for the opportunity granted me and may God bless our homeland, Ghana. Thank you.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, thank you very much for your concluding remarks.

Hon Members, before giving the floor to the Majority Leader, kindly indulge me to acknowledge the presence of visitors at the Public Gallery. First on the list is Philomena Tetteh, Mr King

Daniel Tetteh and Samuel Tetteh. They are coming all the way from Brussels, Belgium to our Parliament to witness our proceedings.

[Visitors from Brussels were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then we also have Cyril King Tetteh and Curtis King Tetteh. They are also from France.

[Visitors from France were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then I have my own classmate, Lieutenant-Colonel Korbieh, Esq. He is also in our midst.

[Lieutenant-Colonel Korbieh, Esq was acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will then proceed to give the floor to the Hon Majority Leader for his concluding remark—*[Hear! Hear!]*— You also have 45 minutes.

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker and let me also thank my Colleague, the Minority Leader, for his remarks on the Mid-Year Review of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy that was presented to this House. The Motion before this House is that this honourable House approves the Mid-Year Review of the Budget Statement on Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2025 Financial Year.

Mr Speaker, I have spent some time in the Chamber and listened to the debate by Colleagues on both Sides of the aisle

and I must say that I have been impressed by the industry and the research that, especially, our new entrants to the Chamber have put into their preparation for the debate. I highly commend our first-timers and their contributions.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Speaker, we have just listened to my Colleague, the Minority Leader, and as he spoke, I recall our days in this Chamber with him and Mr Osei Kyei-Mensah-Bonsu as Majority Leaders. Indeed, the beginning and the end of Ghana's economic problems were in Ukraine—*[Laughter]*—I am tempted to believe that the NPP, as a party and a Government, has benefited more from the Ukraine war than even the Russians who started it. I would not be surprised if Ukraine sues the NPP because the NPP has over-exploited the war.

Mr Speaker, as I listened to the Minority Leader, I recall vividly sitting on the Minority Side and over 88 Members of Parliament on the NPP Side in government, petitioned and indeed, threatening to leave this House because they wanted their very failed Minister for Finance dismissed. Their Minister for Finance had performed so abysmally that over 88 of them marshalled their numbers and wanted the Minister for Finance deposed. I am surprised, today, to hear the Minority Leader attempt to obliterate that record from our history. I, hereby, remind him. Which Minister for Finance? He was boasting of social intervention programmes. Mr Ken Ofori-Atta capped every single social intervention fund in this country. The Ghana Educational Trust Fund (GETFund)

was capped; the District Assemblies Common Fund was capped and the National Health Insurance Fund (NHIF) was capped. Every social intervention was capped. The Road Fund was also capped.

Mr Speaker, it is not a question of who started a social intervention programme. The question is, who most efficiently ran a social intervention programme? And I can say with pride and confidence that, since assuming office, John Dramani Mahama and his Minister for Finance have demonstrated greater commitment to social intervention than anybody has ever done—*[Hear! Hear!]*—We have uncapped GETFund.

We have uncapped the District Assemblies Common Fund; we have uncapped the National Health Insurance Fund (NHIF)—*[Hear! Hear!]*—

4.47 p.m.

We have not only uncapped them, but since assuming office, we have been up to date in payments and none of those Funds have been deprived of any funds. *[Hear! Hear!]* That is how to demonstrate commitment to social intervention funds, not to start them, but to sustain and execute them to the letter of the laws that establish them.

Mr Speaker, I laughed and almost fell off my chair when he mentioned that President Akufo-Addo constructed 13,000km of roads. That has been clearly debunked and I want to tell my Friend, the Minority Leader, that no matter how many times one tells a lie, it still remains

a lie. There is no amount of repetitions of a lie that will transform it into a truth and Ghanaians know that their roads were not done under the NPP.

Mr Speaker, I want to quote the Deputy Managing Director of the International Monetary Fund (IMF), Bo Li, who, recently, to give a clear indication of how the NDC Government is viewed not just by those of us on this Side of the House but by people as far away as Washington, issued a statement and said,

“...faced with large policy slippages and reform delays at end-2024, the new administration has taken bold corrective actions...”

Please, listen. This is the IMF speaking. This is not the Majority Leader. This is not Ato Forson. This is not John Dramani Mahama. This is Bo Li and she says,

“Faced with large policy slippages and reform delays at end-2024, the new administration...”

That is the Administration of President John Dramani Mahama,

“...the new administration has taken bold corrective actions to maintain the programme on track.”

Even the IMF Programme that they began, they delayed in the implementation of the measures because they were afraid of the 2024 December elections. So, there were slippages, delays and all the measures that they were supposed to implement, they did

not implement them. For fear that implementing them may cost them an election that they actually lost in the end. So this is what she said:

“Combined with ongoing reform efforts and an improved external position, the corrective measures are set to support Ghana in reaching the goals of economic stabilization, rebuilding resilience, and fostering higher and more inclusive growth.

The authorities are strongly committed to restoring fiscal discipline and addressing the structural weaknesses that led to the slippages. They have passed a 2025 budget consistent with the program’s objectives and enacted an enhanced fiscal responsibility framework. Looking ahead, staying the course of fiscal adjustment and completing the debt restructuring are key to ensure fiscal sustainability.”

Mr Speaker, so it is not just the Minister, but the IMF have given a clear indication that the measures we have put in place are the right measures. It is not just the IMF; the various credit rating agencies, Fitch Ratings and all of them have given a clear indication that Ghana is on the right path. The economic reform efforts of Ghana have received a major boost as global rating agency, Fitch, upgraded the long-term foreign currency Issuer Default Rating (IDR) of the country from a restricted default to B- with a stable outlook. And that is not just Fitch, all the others have given us a very positive rating.

Mr Speaker, civil society groups—Everybody knows Imani Africa that they are a very impartial organisation; when it is A, they say it is A and when it is B, they say it is B. After the Minister for Finance delivered his Mid-Year Budget Review to this Parliament, the President of Imani Africa, Franklin Cudjoe, clearly threw his support behind the Minister for Finance and the policy measures that he has been implementing.

Mr Speaker, when you look at the Mid-Year Budget Review, you will take ten key points. The Mid-Year Budget Review does not request for extra funds. We are not asking for extra funds. An approval is requested, but the approval is simply based on the fact that there is some multi-year expenditure item and Section 33 of our Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921) indicates that it has to receive parliamentary approval.

Mr Speaker, very good news reported in the Mid-Year Budget Report. Public debts dropped by GH¢113.7 billion. *[Hear! Hear!]* Mr Speaker, the NPP left us with a debt exceeding GH¢726.7 billion—**[Some Hon Members: Eii!]**—Within five months of becoming the Minister for Finance, Ato Forson was able to drop this debt by GH¢113.7 billion. *[Hear! Hear!]* This is clearly unprecedented.

Somebody asked that where did he get the money from and that it is exchange rate? It takes intelligence to know that you can use exchange rate to pay your debts. It takes economic wizardry to know that you can use exchange rates alone to pay a lot of your

debts. Why did Ofori-Atta not use exchange rates to pay the debts? Why did he not?

Mr Speaker, another key point that we take from the Mid-Year Budget Review is that we are going to approach our infrastructure development more intentionally than we have done in the past. So, we will not pursue all the 55 major stalled infrastructure projects at once because if we spread ourselves thinly, given our debt obligations, we might not be able to make significant progress. So, the Minister has decided to concentrate on a few of them.

Mr Speaker, the Minister is also following up to ensure that we clean the public sector payroll. He has reported to us that he has conducted a payroll audit and so far, what the audit reveals is that we have identified GH¢150 million in unearned salaries.

This highlights the level of corruption that has pervaded our public sector that we cannot verify 14,000 workers and that 53,311 separated staff are still drawing salaries.

4.57 p.m.

So, 53,311 staff who have left the public service, separated, are still earning salaries from government while we cannot verify 14,000 workers. So, in all, GH¢150 million is going as unearned salaries.

Mr Speaker, another major thing that the Minister has indicated in the Mid-Year Review is that the Sinking Fund is going to be populated with funds again.

Indeed, I recall when the Minister stated that he was going to begin to put US dollars in our foreign accounts and Ghana cedis in our local currency accounts, a Colleague Minister of State shouted, why is he going to do that? All the time when we come, we build these funds and the day we leave office, NPP will come and squander all the funds. Why is he going to build another fund again? So, the NPP will come in future and squander all the funds. I turned to the Minister and I told him that I am very sure that for a very long time the NPP will not come. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, the Minister has also indicated that major reforms are taking place in the energy sector. Indeed, the Energy Sector Levies Act is expected to yield GHC2.9 billion, but that is not enough. There is an effort to transition to gas usage so that we can drastically cut down on our energy expenditure and that is my response to the entreaties of the Minority Leader that we must address the wastages in the energy sector.

Mr Speaker, when you listen to the Mid-Year Review, one theme runs through it and that is the theme of fiscal discipline. By 2023, our economy had gotten to a very critical point. Our debt to GDP ratio had peaked to 84 per cent. Inflation had soared to 54 per cent. I could not believe it when I heard that fiscal deficit shrank from 10.7 per cent of GDP in 2022 to 1.1 per cent of GDP in 2025. These are measures that could not have been achieved without painful fiscal discipline. I was also impressed to see that our debt to GDP had also declined from 84 to 43.8 per cent.

Mr Speaker, clearly, I have heard my Colleague and the NPP complain that we are not spending. It is true that we are not spending on wasteful expenditures. *[Hear! Hear!]*—What is the value to the state when they spent GHC280 million building a structure that they are supposed to spend GHC81 million building? What is the value to the State? So that they can boast that they were spending and they spent GHC280 million to build the Bank of Ghana headquarters when they were told that they could build a structure with GHC81 million—*[Uproar]*—

Mr Speaker, what is the value of spending when they spend hundreds of millions of Ghana cedis to dig a hole in the name of building a cathedral for God? What is the value of spending? How can they commend themselves for spending when they were spending money digging holes and cathedrals were not emerging from those holes?

Mr Speaker, it is true that we may not be spending as much as they would want us to spend and that is because we will not engage in wasteful spending. *[Hear! Hear!]*—I have heard the Minority Leader's response to the Minister's accusation that the inadequacy in terms of revenue generation is as a result of smuggling. But that is the truth. There is excessive smuggling. And on this call, I will urge the security agencies to be up and doing to try and reduce the levels of smuggling that we inherited. Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance has to be commended for the leadership that he has demonstrated in navigating our economy through turbulent global

headwinds. I have heard the Minority wants to go back to the Russia-Ukraine war. This morning, when I left my house, I was watching CNN, and even yesterday, Russia has sent some bombs into Ukraine and bombed some buildings. So, the Russia-Ukraine war has not ended, and yet the cedi has rebounded—[Hear! Hear!]
—Russia is still firing missiles into Ukraine and yet the Ghana cedi has become stronger. Russia is still firing missiles into Ukraine, and yet the cost of fuel products in Ghana has reduced—[Hear! Hear!]
—Russia is still firing missiles into Ukraine, and yet the price of maize has reduced—[Hear! Hear!]
—Russia is still firing missiles into Ukraine, and yet the price of sugar has reduced—[Hear! Hear!]
—Russia is still firing missiles into Ukraine, and yet the price of rice has reduced—[Hear! Hear!]
—Can they explain to Ghanaians why, for all these years, they have heaped every misfortune of Ghana on poor Ukrainians and aggressive Russians, when today they can see that Russia is still firing Ukrainians, and yet the economy is getting better?

Mr Speaker, it is obvious that the NPP spent most of their tenure misleading Ghanaians and lying and attributing every misfortune to the Russians and the Ukrainian misfortunes. But it is obvious that *aban papa* has come, and Ghanaians are seeing the difference, that the cedi has become stronger, the dollar has become weaker, the British pound has become weaker, the major foreign currencies have become weaker in relation to the Ghana cedis, and the Ghana cedis has

appreciated in an unprecedented manner in recent history.

Mr Speaker, they have seen also that interest rates have reduced. I heard the Minority Leader saying that the NDC government is doing nothing about the private sector. Doing nothing about the private sector? How true is that?

5.07 p.m.

Do they really understand the private sector? They are champions of the private sector. Mr Speaker, the champions of the private sector drove interest rates to 40 per cent to an extent that the private sector could not borrow from our banks. That is the champions of the private sector. Since assuming office, interest rates have reduced. Inflation has reduced. The cedi has become stronger. The dollar has reduced. These are the things that the private sector is looking for.

When the private sector is able to go to the bank and there is liquidity in the banks and they can borrow at lower interest rates and expand their businesses, they prefer microeconomic stability as against tax exemptions. The private sector prefers microeconomic stability as against tax exemptions so, the era when every day we were inundated in this House with applications for tax exemptions instead of focusing on driving interest rates down, on reducing inflation, on reducing the exchange rates so that businesses can thrive and create jobs for the people, those days are long gone. [Hear! Hear!]

Mr Speaker, in six months, barely seven months, the private sector is becoming the real engine of growth—*[Hear! Hear!]*—I listened to the Minority Leader. He asked about jobs. He asked, where are the jobs? The jobs are occurring in the private sector. *[Hear! Hear!]* There is a lot of money in the banks chasing businesses. Just walk out and ask any banker. A lot of money in the banks chasing businesses. Do you know why? They are chasing businesses because Government has stopped borrowing from the local banks. Indeed, I have just heard a Colleague MP say that it is not just the private sector. Indeed, they are chasing MPs with loans.

Mr Speaker, the economy is doing well. Growth has rebounded. Our fiscal deficit has reduced to 3.1 per cent of GDP from 7.9 per cent in 2024. Gross international reserves have increased to US\$11.12 billion, covering almost five months of imports. We have achieved a primary surplus for two consecutive quarters, US\$2.1 billion in quarter one of 2025, according to the Bank of Ghana. Debt to GDP ratio declined from 61.8 per cent in December 2024 to 55 per cent through active liability management. Ghana has been upgraded by the major credit ratings agencies. Fitch Ratings upgraded Ghana. Standards and Poor Global Ratings have also revised their ratings on Ghana, and Ghana is looking very good to the international financial institutions. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, there may be some challenges with revenue mobilisation, but even then, the story is very good. In the first quarter of 2025, I think that they

were able to rake in over GH¢5 billion. Efforts are being made to modernise our revenue collection agencies, and we believe that very soon we will begin to see real progress in that sector.

Mr Speaker, we will spend, but we will spend wisely. We will be spending over GH¢28.7 billion on Capital Expenditure. In the 2024 Budget, the NPP spent only GH¢28.7 billion, but in our 2025 Budget, we have allocated GH¢32.9 billion to Capital Expenditure so, we will spend. Mr Speaker, we are spending on all the social intervention programmes, and we have increased them. Senior High Schools are well taken care of.

Indeed, Mr Speaker, there is innovation in social intervention. Under the NPP government, who claim they are private sector orientated, they spent mostly on public sector institutions but this year, we are spending on 60 private Senior High Schools—*[Hear! Hear!]*—so, we are not only spending on Government Senior High Schools, but we are also spending on some Private Senior High Schools. So, we are including the private sector, even in spending on social intervention. We have increased the allocation to Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty programme (LEAP). We have increased the capitation grant. We have increased almost every social intervention programme.

Mr Speaker, we are strategic in our direction. We are going to focus on agricultural transformation. Indeed, we are already beginning to see progress in the agricultural sector. In the Mid-Year

Review, we are told that agriculture led in the growth figures of this half year so, clearly, we are making progress in the area of agriculture, and that is how we intend to drive down food inflation.

Mr Speaker, we are investing in the development bank, and the development bank has already announced a 500 million financial support programme for the agricultural sector.

Mr Speaker, we are expanding the digital economy, and our abolition of the obnoxious electronic levy has given confidence and many more people are involved in electronic transactions—*[Hear! Hear!]*—In April 2025 alone, mobile money transactions reached an all-time high of GHC351.7 billion — *[Hear! Hear!]*— Mr Speaker, that is how much confidence Ghanaians now have, having abolished the electronic levy (E-levy), and Ghanaians are using the electronic highway to transact their businesses. *[Hear! Hear!]*

The number of transactions increased from 764 million transactions in March 2025 to 778 million transactions in April; that is just one month's jump. Mr Speaker, it is clear that the policy that we initiated and implemented in the abolition of the E-levy is indeed generating positive results.

But Mr Speaker, we are not yet out of the woods and so we will take constructive criticism. We need to continue the fiscal discipline. We need to spend, but spend in the right places. We need to fight corruption. We need to transform our governance. We need to create jobs for the youth. We need to

invest more in agriculture and I can see that when you read the new initiatives outlined by the Minister for Finance, these are the new focus areas so, we have launched the jobs for the youth.

5.17 p.m.

We have also launched and established the Gold Board, which is also having an impact in terms of the reduction in the dollar rate to the cedi, and all these interventions are generating positive results.

But most importantly, Mr Speaker, this NDC Government is a Government that has kept every promise that we have made to Ghanaians so far. We promised to establish a lean Government, and we have established a lean Government — *[Hear! Hear!]*— We have appointed only 60 Ministers and Deputy Ministers of state, because that was what we promised Ghanaians. We have abolished the development authorities, except the Northern Development Authority, which originally was what was agreed on until the whole area became flooded with all sorts of development authorities.

Mr Speaker, the fight against corruption continues relentlessly, and the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is going to prosecute all those who were involved in corruption under the NPP Administration; we will not be deterred. Corruption has to be fought, because if we do not fight corruption, all the gains that we are registering will be lost in no time.

Mr Speaker, the 24-Hour Economy, which is a key pillar in our economic

strategy, will be rolled out very soon. I have listened to the Minority Leader. He has provided some useful suggestions, and I can assure him that I have sat in Cabinet, and many of the things that he raised are indeed, key considerations in implementing a 24-Hour Economy. We need an infrastructure base to support running an economy for 24 hours. Key among them is energy. So we are taking steps to boost our energy generation capacity in the country.

We are taking steps to boost law enforcement capabilities so that people can work 24 hours without fear of crime and violence. Indeed, we are looking at the various possible economic nodes. So the northern sector will have a whole strategy that it will focus on. The Volta Basin will have a whole strategy that it will focus on. The Coastal Belt will have a whole strategy that it will focus on as well as the cities, the rural areas, and the mining sectors. Every sector of our economy has some strategy that we are focusing on as part of the 24-Hour Economy strategy.

Very soon, we will bring the directorate of the 24-Hour Economy to come and give us further briefings on the details of the rolling out of that programme. So let me assure them that the 24-Hour Economy will be implemented, and it is going to be a game-changer. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, our economy is turning around. We are recovering. Inflation has come down. The cedi has rebounded; the dollar has reduced in value in relation to the cedi. Fiscal discipline is being adhered to. We are fighting corruption

strenuously, and we are retooling our public sector to make it more efficient, more effective and also less wasteful of public resources.

The Minister for Finance, Hon Ato Forson, needs to be highly commended for his leadership. He needs to be highly commended for his discipline. He needs to be highly commended for his wisdom. Mr Speaker, in the past, we were told of some economic wizards being paired with certain candidates so that they would perform economic miracles. When those wizards assumed office, all the children in the village were crucified.

Mr Speaker, the economy was brought to a standstill. It collapsed. Ato Forson is not a Vice-President; Ato Forson is just one of us, a Colleague Member of Parliament that we elevated to the Minister for Finance. And within seven months, he has done things that have never been seen in the history of the financial management of this country. **[Some Hon Members: Ato o, Ato!]**

Mr Speaker, I want to conclude on the note of Bawku. We are not running away from Bawku. We, the NDC Government, are not running away from Bawku. For those Hon Members who have chosen to have a very short memory, Bawku was a very peaceful place from 1984 till 2001, when Kufuor took over as President. That is it. Those are the facts.

Mr Speaker, they do not know about Bawku. Let me tell them about Bawku. They can go and check the records. If they want us to debate it, I can fix a date, we will debate it, and I will give them the

records. Mr Speaker, the problem in Bawku was caused under the NPP Administration. That was what happened. While Akufo-Addo was President, he allowed somebody to be appointed as a rival chief in Bawku and that is the cause of the problem. And during Akufo-Addo's Administration, that rival chief was taken into Bawku. That is the cause of the problem of Bawku. I am assuring them that President John Dramani Mahama will solve the Bawku problem once and for all.

We are not rushing. We do not want to be populist. We have confidence in the Asantehene, and we leave the matter in his hands. I can assure them that the issue at Bawku will be solved.

Mr Speaker, on that note, let me thank our Friends in the Minority. Why am I thanking them? They stayed away from the presentation of the Mid-Year Budget, but they came to debate the Mid-Year Budget. So I thank them. Let me thank the Majority because we have been steadfast with the Minister for Finance, supported him, implemented all his policies and enacted all the legislation that has enabled the positive gains that we are seeing in the economy to the benefit of ordinary Ghanaians.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.
[Some Hon Members: Leader! o Leader!]

[Members of both Majority and Minority sang]

[Mr First Deputy Speaker rises to be heard in silence pursuant to Standing Order 126(2)]

5.27 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, can we have some order? Order!

Hon Members, may I, please, ask whether the Deputy Minister for Finance will want to make a concluding remark.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I know my Brother, Osahen Afenyo-Markin. There are times when Togbe will exercise his magnanimity and his sense of mercy in a way that surprises everybody and I know that this is one of those times when we will be able to prevail on the Osahen to allow the Deputy Minister for Finance to conclude on—*[Interruption]*—Normally, when we finish, the Ministers are allowed to thank us for the messages, the arguments, the debates, the pieces of advice and constructive criticisms that are embedded in this debate. I believe that, given that the Minister for Finance is unavoidably absent, my Brother will allow the Deputy Minister, who is one of us and a Friend of the Osahen, conclude on behalf of the Minister for Finance. I make an application for him to be allowed to conclude on behalf of the Minister for Finance.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, the Leader of Government Business has made an application. Such applications are generally not opposed, but, since he says that the Deputy Minister is going to thank us and also to assure us that he will carry the sentiment of the House to

Government, I pray that this will be done.

Mr Speaker, our respected Friend, Mr Ampem Nyarko, loves to debate. The past days that we started this debate, I have not seen him on the list. I know that he would be tempted to debate. Therefore, the Hon Deputy Minister knows that we have a long way to go in this House, so he should not breach trust; he should not throw any low blow—
[Laughter]

Mr Speaker, I will yield to the prayer of the Leader of the House, but, please, the Deputy Minister for Finance should just be in his diplomatic best and, within two minutes, he should do the right thing, so that, in future when an application is made for him, we will not oppose it. He knows he has a business here; what actually brought him was his business and we have also agreed to the Order Paper *Addendum*. So, anything negative he does may affect—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, I can assure you that the Deputy Minister for Finance will not do anything negative.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I just also want to say this to assure my back that he will do the right thing.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Before giving the floor to the Deputy Minister for Finance, let me acknowledge the presence of Projects Abroad, led by Theophilus Atujona, who is the Regional

Coordinator. They are from various countries: Germany, France, the USA, the UK, and Colombia. They are 15 in number. On behalf of the House, I welcome you and may you have a fruitful stay.

[Members of Projects Abroad were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Minister for Finance, you have the floor.

5.37 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, my grandfather told me about patience and posterity—
[Interruption]—No, under normal circumstances, this should be nothing, but, Mr Speaker, when I am even using the despatch box, they would raise all manner of thing, but it is all right.

Mr Speaker, the mood in this House is one of cooperation; I will not object to him using it. It is fine, but Colleagues should always remember, the evil they do to others would always come and haunt them, but I have no problem.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Ampem, please, get up at your place and then address us. No, just be there.

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem): Mr Speaker, on 24th of this month, the Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, was in this House on the authority of H. E. President John Dramani Mahama, to present the Mid-Year Review of the 2025 Budget in line with Section 28 of

the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921).

Subsequently, Mr Speaker, as has been the practice in this House and in accordance with our Standing Orders, Members have taken turns to express their opinions on the Statement presented by my boss.

Mr Speaker, today, I count myself the luckiest Deputy Minister in the Administration of President Mahama because Ato is the best Minister any Deputy can wish for. *[Hear! Hear!]* It seldom happens that a Minister for Finance will yield such an important podium to his Deputy. Dr Ato Forson, God bless you.

Mr Speaker, may I take this opportunity to thank Hon Members for an engaging debate, some made in good faith and others with obvious mischief and misrepresentations. Since our Colleagues on the other Side were not present to listen to the Minister for Finance at first hand, we may forgive them for their misrepresentations since they may be speaking based on hearsay.

However, Mr Speaker, kindly permit me to correct some of the misrepresentations made by some Colleague Members. The Hon Abena Osei-Asare stated and I quote, “if the cedi has appreciated against the US dollar, external interest payments should come down; it has rather increased by GH¢1 billion”. Mr Speaker, I want to state that this assertion is totally incorrect.

In fact, Appendix 2C of the Mid-Year Statement indicated under external interest payments that out of the GH¢3.97 billion that was programmed to be paid within the first half of the year, GH¢3.7 billion was actually paid, resulting in a savings of GH¢179 billion—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin —*rose*—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minister, hold it. Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I want the Majority Leader to lend support to this. He is a lawyer; I take him by his word. It should not be that somebody is being set up for embarrassment. The man has a prepared speech. I have no problem if we had not closed the debate; we have closed the debate. The application was that he was going to thank us.

Colleagues, let us not do this to ourselves, then when there is a reaction, it is as if somebody is being unreasonable—*[Interruption]*—No. Your Leader has spoken for 45 minutes. If you had rebuttals, your duty was to give them to him to rebut. You cannot seize this opportunity to say that you are coming to re-argue. No. Let us not go there.

Mr Speaker, that was not the understanding—*[Interruption]*—No. That was not the understanding. They said he is thanking and taking the concerns on board. Please, do not use—he has about four pages; he is now going to re-argue again. No. Mr Speaker, it is

not fair. That was not the understanding. If he is thanking us, as courtesy demands, he should do so—

Majority Leader, please, intervene and get this thing resolved, so that we do not get matters to degenerate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, you have made your point.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, you know, historically, any time we finish debating, the Minister for Finance concludes and he thanks us, but this is a house of record, so if the Minister for Finance, hearing the debates, thinks that there is a factual inaccuracy and he uses an opportunity to thank us to correct it, there is nothing wrong with that.

I heard him say that there were some claims made during the debate and he is now going to correct them. So, for the records, he wants to place things in proper perspective. This is the amount that was given and this is the amount that was paid and this is the amount that was saved. I thought that was what I heard him say. So, he is just correcting some records; otherwise, in our debate, we would have misinformed the public. If he begins to say something that is contentious, they can raise an objection. But if he is just correcting the records, I think that we should allow him to correct the records because he is the one keeping the records.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have all been in this House

for some time. When debates are concluded by the Leaders, opportunity is given to the Minister who presents the Budget to comment. We do not give conditions based on which the Minister is supposed to make the concluding comments.

Hon Members, there are senior Members in this House and they know the practice. The Minister is not here, but the Deputy Minister is stepping into the shoes of the Minister, so we cannot prevent the Minister from making concluding comments. He brought the Budget that has been debated, so, at the end of the debate, it is fair when we take comments from the Minister.

Hon Deputy Minister, you have the floor.

Mr Ampem: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I got to the point where I was reacting to a statement made by my good Friend, Hon Abena Osei-Asare and I quote:

“If the cedi has appreciated against the US dollar, external interest payments should come down; it has rather increased by GH¢ billion.”

Mr Speaker, I want to state that this assertion is totally incorrect. In fact, Appendix 2C of the Mid-Year Budget Statement indicated, under external interest payments, that out of the GH¢3.97 billion that was programmed to be paid within the first half of the year, GH¢3.7 billion was actually paid, resulting in a savings of GH¢179 million

as a result of the cedis appreciation. These savings can build about 206-unit classroom blocks across the country, including Atiwa. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Paragraph 248 of the Mid-Year Budget Statement stated clearly that external interest payments have been revised upward by GH¢795 million and not GH¢1 billion to make provision for additional debt service due on post-cut-off-debt disbursements on bilateral loans that the previous Administration made in 2023.

5.47 p.m.

Again, Hon Abena Osei-Asare, said there has been no real impact beyond the numbers in the Mid-Year Budget Review. “Ghanaians do not live in the Mid-Year Review; they live in the economy. The Mid-Year was full of technical jargons.”

Mr Speaker, if there has been any Budget presentation that has been made simple for the ordinary Ghanaian to understand, it is the one presented by Dr Cassiel Ato Forson. Does Hon Abena Osei-Asare really believe that the improvement in the economy in the past six months has had no impact on the lives of Ghanaians?

Let me remind my Colleagues that within these six months, importers will testify that import duties have drastically reduced. *[Hear! Hear!]* The real income of households which was eroded by an inflation of 23.8 per cent have seen a significant improvement with a reduction of inflation to 13.7 per cent. Assembly members in Atiwa East are

GH¢1,300 richer every month. *[Hear! Hear!]* All Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) beneficiaries are receiving more than they used to and promptly. Price of petrol has reduced from an average of GH¢14.72 per litre to GH¢12.23 per litre. Mr Speaker, these and many more are the real occurrences in the economy that Ghanaian people can feel.

Mr Speaker, one of the renowned pollsters in Ghana today, the Global InfoAnalytics have been conducting periodic surveys and they did one on standard of living. Mr Speaker, last year, around July 2024, their survey indicated that for standard of living, 47 per cent of Ghanaians said that their standard of living had worsened. Mr Speaker, fast forward, this year, the same question was posed in July, 2025. Guess what? Only 12 per cent of Ghanaians said that their standard of living had worsened and 59 per cent of Ghanaians say that their standard of living has improved. *[Hear! Hear!]* Mr Speaker, the same time last year, only 21 per cent of Ghanaians believed that their standard of living had improved.

Mr Speaker, what is even more interesting is that when we recorded standard of living improvement optimism, one year ago, the Global InfoAnalytics survey revealed that 20 per cent of respondents said that there was no improvement in their standard of living. But Mr Speaker, the interesting part is that today, 72 per cent of Ghanaians say that they are highly optimistic that their standard of living will improve against the 20 per cent from

last year who thought that their standard of living will improve.

Mr Speaker, Hon Mohammed Amin Adam, the immediate past Minister for Finance, suggested that Dr Forson cannot take credit for the reduction in the debt-to-GDP ratio because he, Dr Amin Adam, negotiated the cancellation of over US\$5 billion of Ghana's debt. Mr Speaker, I want to state emphatically that the reduction in Ghana's public debt from GH¢726.7 billion in December, 2024 to GH¢613 billion as at the end of June, 2025 has nothing to do with any purported debt cancellation. Ghana has not benefited from any debt cancellation in the past six months period that we are reviewing. The over GH¢113 billion reduction is as a result of the cedi's appreciation against the US dollar, something that seemed impossible under their tenure.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Gideon Boako, an advisor to the former Vice President, provided some wrong debt figures in his submission to suggest that the -15.6 per cent debt accumulation is not novel. He misled this House by stating that the November, 2022 public debt stock was GH¢382.7 billion.

Mr Speaker, for the record, the Bank of Ghana's summary of economic and financial data published by Governor Addison in May 2023 showed that the debt stock as of November 2022 was GH¢575.7 billion and not the GH¢382.7 billion quoted by the Hon Member. The Minister for Finance stated, and I want to reiterate, that the negative debt accumulation recorded within the first

half of this year has never happened in the history of our dear nation.

Mr Speaker, unlike his immediate predecessors, the Minister for Finance did not blame the performance of the economy on any external factor in the entire one and a half hours of presentation. In fact, the Russia-Ukraine war is still ongoing. There are even more negative external factors like the war in the Middle East and tariff wars, but in spite of all these, we have performed.

Mr Speaker, we all recall how a certain "driver's mate" took control of the economy and recklessly drove it into a ditch; a ditch so deep that what we inherited was nothing short of an economic crisis marked by deep debt distress and mounting debt service harms; a country with dispirited citizens. In the midst of all this, the public —

[5.54 p.m. — Members of the Minority walked out of the Chamber]

[Some Hon Members of the Majority chanted "Away! Away!"]

A country with dispirited citizens, rising costs of living for an ordinary Ghanaian, collapsing confidence in our public finances, trust and faith in our leaders were at an all-time low, the fundamentals were not only weak but broken, the misery and suffering were palpable, and in the midst of all this, the public purse was subjected to massive abuse and in the words of the Catholic Bishops' Conference, "massive uncontrolled corruption" was the order of the day.

Mr Speaker, let me re-emphasise that the last 205 days of our stewardship under the leadership of His Excellency John Dramani Mahama have been marked by consistent and sustained macroeconomic stability. Mr Speaker, these gains are not episodic; they are the fruits of a carefully crafted and boldly implemented sound economic policies, anchored of discipline, vision and a deep sense of responsibility to the Ghanaian people.

Mr Speaker, this marks the end of an era of empty political sloganeering. We remain unwavering in our commitment to deliver stable prices and decent jobs for our fellow countrymen and women. The signs are clear, we are indeed building back better, brick by brick, step by step and little by little. Mr Speaker, let our Friends on the other Side who have just walked out take note that recovery is not by press conferences, it is not by walkouts, it is not found in recycled rhetoric or speculative pessimism.

5.57 p.m.

It is earned through policy perseverance and performance. *[Hear! Hear!]* Mr Speaker, Ghana is rising again. The foundation is being rebuilt, the confidence is returning and the momentum of our recovery is becoming stronger.

Mr Speaker, our economic model is delivering results because it is being championed with vision and dedication by His Excellency President John Dramani Mahama. In paragraph 537 of the Mid-Year Budget Statement, the Minister for Finance gave a tall list of

payments we have made. Let me take a few of them to demonstrate that this is a marked improvement over what we have seen in the past: District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF) — From January to June 2024, DACF had been paid GH¢2.3 billion. But from January to June this year, we have paid DACF GH¢2.9 billion. The GETFund received only GH¢1.2 billion between January and June 2024. But the same period, January to June 2025, we have paid GETFund GH¢4.6 billion. The National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS) was paid GH¢1.8 billion between January and June 2024. Between January and June this year, we have paid the NHIS GH¢4.6 billion. Transfer to SSNIT for the first six months of 2024, was only GH¢1 billion. The first half of 2025, we have transferred GH¢2.7 billion to the Social Security and National Insurance Trust (SSNIT). In fact, on the 24th, the day that the Minister for Finance was presenting the Mid-Year Budget Review, we transferred another GH¢300 million to SSNIT, making it GH¢3 billion. As at the end of December 2024, transfers to SSNIT were in arrears of more than GH¢2.2 billion. But this year, no arrears have been accumulated. We are up to date and we will continue to be up to date until the end of the year. Teachers and nursing training allowances have been paid in full as of June 2025, and from this month are receiving their allowances on a monthly basis. As I speak now, the July 2025 allowances have been paid. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, a good government always takes steps to protect the

vulnerable in society. So, President Mahama has increased LEAP and has paid promptly. He has increased school feeding and has paid promptly. He has increased capitation grants and paid promptly.

Another significant improvement in the Budget implementation this year is in the area of releases to Metropolitan, Municipal, District Assemblies (MMDAs). The Sekondi-Takoradi Metropolitan Assembly was paid DACF of GH¢700,686 in the first quarter of 2024. In the second quarter, they were sent another GH¢700,686. In the third quarter, they were sent the same amount, GH¢700,686. In the whole of 2024, they received three transfers. The total was GH¢2.1 million. But guess what? In 2025, first quarter alone, Sekondi-Takoradi Metropolitan Assembly has received GH¢3.1 million. That is GH¢1 million more than the total amount received in the whole of 2024. And guess what? Second quarter, Sekondi-Takoradi Metropolitan Assembly is receiving GH¢5.8 million. So, if you put the first two quarters, the first half of the year, Sekondi-Takoradi Metropolitan Assembly alone is getting GH¢9 million compared to GH¢2.1 million for the whole of 2024.

In fact, I am sad the Minority Leader has walked out. The next Assembly I am taking is Effutu Municipal Assembly. I know he is listening from his office. The good people of Effutu. First quarter of 2024, the Government of the NPP transferred only GH¢478,712 to Effutu Municipal Assembly. The same amount was transferred in the second quarter and

in the third quarter, the same GH¢478,712. The irony of it, we know that transfers to Common Fund is a function of revenue. How surprising and how convenient is it that the same amount goes to the Assembly each quarter? It shows that they were cooking figures. The total amount received by Effutu Municipal Assembly for the whole of 2024 was GH¢1.4 million. By first quarter 2025, we have sent Effutu Municipal Assembly GH¢2.9 million. The second quarter, Effutu Municipal Assembly is receiving GH¢5.3 million. The two quarters put together was GH¢8.3 million for Effutu, Winneba, alone.

In fact, the next Assembly I wanted to talk about is Karaga, the Assembly of the immediate past Minister for Finance, Hon Mohamed Amin Adam. As Minister for Finance, he supervised the transfer of a meagre amount of GH¢414,419 for the first quarter, the same for the second quarter and the same for the third quarter of 2024. The total amount received by Karaga District Assembly in the former Minister for Finance's District was GH¢1.2 million. Dr Ato Forson through DACF has sent GH¢2.2 million to Karaga in the first quarter of 2025 alone. Second quarter amounts to Karaga is GH¢4,070,000.

Mr Speaker, President Mahama is determined to deepen fiscal decentralisation and spur development at the local level. This is a sharp departure from the retrogressive recentralisation of resources witnessed under the previous regime.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance in his conclusion to the Mid-Year Review Statement made a profound statement that “*Aban papa aba*”. Indeed, the signs of economic progress are visible and measurable. First quarter economic growth is at a five-year high because *aban papa aba*. The consumer confidence index rose from 87.7 in April 2024 to 103.6 in April 2025 because *aban papa aba*. Business confidence index of 105.5 compared to 88.8 last year because *aban papa aba*. Inflation has declined from 23.8 per cent in December 2024 to 13.7 per cent in June 2025 because *aban papa aba*—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: To wit?

Mr Ampem: A good government is here. Prices of sugar, rice and cooking oil are at a four-year low because *aban papa aba*. We injected GHC2 billion into the National Investment Bank securing hundreds of jobs and protecting depositor funds because *aban papa aba*. By lowering treasury bill rates and strengthening the cedi, we have saved over GHC5.1 billion in interest payments because *aban papa aba*. Public debt has reduced by over GHC113 billion in just six months because *aban papa aba*. Debt to GDP has reduced from 61.8 per cent in December 2024 to 43.8 per cent in June 2025 because *aban papa aba*. The Ghanaian Cedi has appreciated by a whopping 42.6 per cent against the U.S. dollar because *aban papa aba*. Ghana’s credit rating has improved from junk status to B- with a stable outlook because *aban papa aba*. The 91-day treasury bill rate has declined from 27.7 per cent per annum in December 2024 to 10.84 per

cent per annum in July 2025 because *aban papa aba*.

4.57 p.m.

Ghana’s gross international reserves have risen from US\$8.98 billion to US\$11.12 billion, now covering 4.8 months of imports because *aban papa aba*. Mr Speaker, Ghanaians are now happy because *aban papa aba*. In fact, *aban bɔne kɔ* and *aban papa aba*.

Thank you and may God bless us all.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, indeed, on Thursday 24th July, 2025, the Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, moved the Motion numbered 8 on today’s Order Paper. The Motion was seconded by Hon Richard Acheampong.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved:

That this honourable House approves the Mid-Year Review of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2025 Financial Year.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us turn to Order Paper *Addendum*, At the Commencement of Public Business, Presentation of Papers.

Minister for Finance?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Minister is not in the Chamber, but with your indulgence, we can allow the

Deputy Minister for Finance to lay the Paper on the Order Paper *Addendum*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Deputy Minister for Finance may lay the Paper on the Order Paper *Addendum*.

PAPER

By the Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem) on behalf of the Minister for Finance —

Exemptions Regulations, 2025.

Referred to the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we have not done five hours yet, so we are in your hands.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, we have not done five hours.

Mr Ayariga: Yes, Mr Speaker, I move that the House adjourns to tomorrow at 10 o'clock in the forenoon.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The House is accordingly adjourned till Friday, 1st August, 2025 at 10:00 a.m.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 6.12 p.m. till Friday, 1st August, 2025 at 10.00 a.m.

